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Cong. bore the blame for DMK's mistakes: Tagore

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Trade deals made from a 'position of strength', says Modi

Slew of trade agreements will expand global market access for MSMEs, says PM; he urges private sector to take advantage of policy framework

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

India recently entered into a slew of trade agreements, including with the European Union and the United States, "from a position of strength", Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Sunday, adding that these deals were designed to expand global market access for Indian manufacturing and services.
In a written interview to the Press Trust of India, Mr. Modi said that the 2026 Budget gave the private sector the opportunity to step up and take advantage of government's investment in infrastructure and capital expenditure.

This is not a 'now or never' moment born out of compulsion. It is a 'we are ready' moment born out of preparation and inspiration. This Budget reflects this yearning to become a developed nation

NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister



"This is not a 'now or never' moment born out of compulsion. It is a 'we are ready' moment born out of preparation and inspiration. This Budget reflects this yearning to become a developed nation."

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

Opposition slams PM's interview

NEW DELHI
The Congress dismissed Prime Minister Narendra Modi's interview with the Press Trust of India as a "carefully scripted" one and a "desperate PR exercise". » PAGE 10

Going berserk



Hitting away: Ishan Kishan's blistering 77 helped India score 175 for seven, which proved too much for Pakistan to surmount in their T20 World Cup match in Colombo on Sunday. GETTY IMAGES (REPORT: PAGE 15)

AI Impact Summit begins today

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

Kicking off the India AI Impact Summit, Prime Minister Narendra Modi will inaugurate the India AI Impact Expo 2026 on Monday. Global tech moguls and leaders of nearly 20 countries are among representatives from some 100 countries expected to attend the meet, the first such event in the Global South, which will end on February 20. The summit will push for equitable access to AI resources, a senior government official said on Sunday, adding that India is focusing the summit on a "human-centric" approach.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 12

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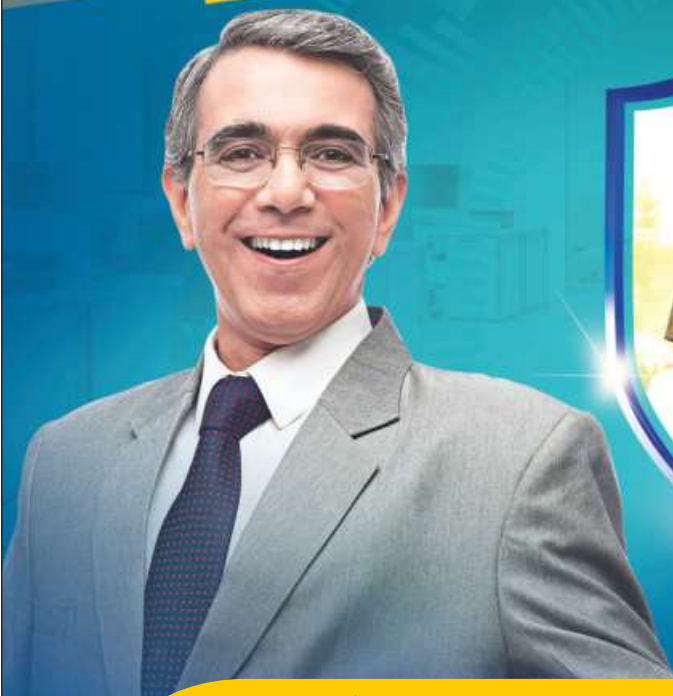
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INBRIEF



MSSW presents Mary Clubwala Jadhav Award

The Madras School of Social Work (MSSW) on Saturday presented the 30th Mary Clubwala Jadhav Award for Humanitarian Service to Bal Pandian, popularly known as the 'Bird Man of Koothankulam', and Thuvakkam Welfare Association, an NGO, for their contributions to conservation. R. Nataraj, MSSW secretary, presented the awards, along with a cash prize of ₹1 lakh each. A press release said Arun Krishnamurthy, founder, Environmentalist Foundation of India, delivered an endowment lecture emphasising environmental responsibility as integral to humanitarian service. He highlighted the need to remove encroachments along waterbodies and restore lakes, warning of ecological imbalance and species decline. K.A. Mathew, president, MSSW, delivered the presidential address. MSSW principal S. Raja Samuel, and dean R. Subashini were among the participants.

GCC imposes ₹1 lakh fine for C&D waste norm violation

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) has imposed a fine of ₹1 lakh for violation of its guidelines for clean and safe building practices. The invoice, dated February 14, 2026, cites violation beyond 20,000 sq. m. under the name 'Southern Railway Parking Campus'. GCC Commissioner J. Kumaragurubaran said action was taken under prescribed norms for disposing of construction and debris waste.

Private conservancy players of GCC to collect trash from bulk waste generators in city

The initiative aims to reduce the burden on these generators, who currently face challenges in managing waste; it is likely to improve solid waste management in over 3,000 neighbourhoods

CITY MATTERS

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

Private conservancy operators of the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) are likely to start collecting garbage from large apartment complexes, IT buildings, and large commercial buildings that generate huge quantities of waste.

The bulk waste generators will no longer have to process waste on their own premises or hand over waste to other empanelled small vendors once the GCC gives its approval to two major private conservancy operators to collect waste from large buildings with an area of over 5,000 sq. m., and buildings that generate 100 kg of waste per day, civic officials said.

Those bulk operators who are already processing waste on their premises will continue to do decentralised waste processing. According to



The GCC has decided to make changes after receiving complaints about illegal dumping of waste in public spaces. FILE PHOTO

the existing rules, bulk waste generators have to make arrangements for decentralised processing of waste by developing waste processing facilities on their own premises.

They have also been permitted to avail themselves of the services of 19 empanelled vendors for disposal of waste to the dump yards.

As a number of complaints have been received about illegal dumping of waste in public spaces by some vendors who collect the waste from the bulk waste generators, the civic body has decided to make

the change, said officials.

Some of the empanelled vendors were not disposing of the waste at Perungudi and Kodungaiyur dump yards as they have to pay charges to the Chennai Corporation for dumping them. Several bulk waste generators have also been unable to find the right vendors to dispose of the waste.

Once the two major private conservancy operators, Ramky and Urbaser Sumeet, are permitted by the GCC to collect waste directly from the bulk waste generators, garbage problems are expected to be

resolved in more than 3,000 neighbourhoods.

The GCC had conducted a meeting last week to expand the scope of solid waste management by the private operators in the city, with the aim of improving waste collection from bulk waste generators, strengthening garbage clearance from open spaces such as burial grounds, and for promoting cleanliness in residential areas of the Tamil Nadu Urban Habitat Development Board (TNUHDB).

Federation of North Chennai Residents Welfare Associations president T.K. Shanmugham said the bulk waste generators should emulate the model adopted by apartment complexes that have facilities for waste processing on their own premises. "We are studying a successful model adopted by an apartment complex in Thiruvanniyur. If we do not encourage decentralised processing, it may lead to large scale dumping of waste in dump yards," he said.



Infra boost: The 652-metre-long flyover with 19 spans is uni-directional. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Traffic woes to ease at Madhya Kailash as Stalin opens flyover

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Sunday inaugurated the newly constructed ₹60.68-crore 'L'-shaped flyover at the Sardar Patel Road-Rajiv Gandhi Salai junction.

The flyover at the Madhya Kailash junction in south Chennai will allow vehicles proceeding to Rajiv Gandhi Salai from Guindy to turn right, avoiding the traffic signal. The Chief Minister's convoy was the first to use the flyover.

The 652-metre-long facility with 19 spans is uni-directional and two lanes wide.

The right turn at the top is built with a radius of 45

metres to ensure the safety of motorists.

The flyover has been designed for a maximum speed of 30 km/hr, and several other safety features, such as taller retaining walls at the turn, and warning signs, have been incorporated.

It is expected to reduce congestion at the junction as it is estimated that 60% of the traffic from Guindy would take a right turn into OMR.

Highways Minister E.V. Velu, Health Minister Ma. Subramanian, MP Thamizhachi Thangapandian, Highways Secretary R. Selvaraj, and Chief Engineer Jawahar Muthuraj were present on the occasion.

Australian, U.S. authorities agree to hand over five idols

R. Sivaraman
CHENNAI

The Idol Wing-CID of the Tamil Nadu Police have said Australian and U.S. authorities had agreed to repatriate five idols to Tamil Nadu due to its sustained efforts.

Officials said the recovered artefacts were being brought back to the State

through the Mutual Legal Assistance Treaty (MLAT) route, and subsequently handed over to the respective temples after due legal procedures. Investigations by the Idol Wing-CID revealed that several missing antique metal idols had surfaced in prominent international museums, institutions, and auction houses abroad.

Additional Director-General of Police, Idol Wing-CID, Kalpana Nayak said in a recent breakthrough that authorities in Australia have agreed to repatriate three antique metal idols dating back to the 12th Century, while the U.S. has consented to return two more idols. In total, five idols will be repatriated to Tamil Nadu.

The three idols that will be repatriated from the National Gallery of Australia in Canberra are a trident with the auspicious Kali (Bhadrakali) worth about ₹2 crore, a stone idol of Nandi (Sacred Bull) belonging to the Arulmigu Kailasanathar temple of Kaduvankudi village in Tiruvapur district worth ₹4 crore, and a stone idol of

Six-Headed Skanda – Karthikeya (Subramanya) belonging to the Arulmigu Naganathaswamy temple of Manambadi village worth about ₹2 crore.

The National Museum of Asian Art, Smithsonian Institution of the U.S., agreed to return two metal sculptures kept in the Freer-Sackler Museum in Washington DC.

The two are Sundarar and Paravai Nachiyar belonging to the Arulmigu Nareeswarar Sivan Temple of Veera Cholanur village in Kallakurichi district, constructed 900 years ago, and Somaskandar (12th-13th Century) belonging to the Arulmigu Viswanathasamy Temple in Alathur village of Tiruvapur district.

Text & Context and Science
Weekly features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (February 16, Monday), the following articles are available:

- Ambiguities in the U.S.-India trade deal newsth.live/tradedealex
- Austrian cow shows how cattle can use tools newsth.live/cattletools

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

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RISE 06:31 SET 18:15
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TUESDAY, FEB. 17
RISE 06:31 SET 18:15
RISE 06:18 SET 18:13

WEDNESDAY, FEB. 18
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MTC driver found dead in Porur Lake

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The police recovered the body of a 52-year-old man from Porur Lake on Saturday night.

The deceased has been identified as D. Chandran, of Corporation Colony in T. Nagar, who was working as a bus driver attached to the T. Nagar Depot of the Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC).

Residents found the body floating in the lake on Saturday evening and alerted the SRMC Police Station of the Avadi city police. Based on the information, the police team, along with fire and rescue services personnel, went to the lake and recovered the body. The police sent the body to a government hospital.

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I, Arul Prakash Vedanarayanan, S/o Vedanarayanan Sekkiah, born on 23/06/1996, residing at 508, Vaduvor road, Keelapattu, Rayapuram, Thiruvannur, Tamil Nadu - 612803, have changed my name to Arul Prakash (Given Name: Arul, Surname: Prakash) for all future purposes vide affidavit dated 05/02/2026, sworn before Notary S.N. Narasimulu, Chennai.

My Son VS. ADITYA., Born on 01st Mar 2023 (Native: Chennai), residing at J204, Isha Yara Apartments, Vadakumpattu Main road, Medavakkam, Chennai - 600100 shall henceforth be known as ADITHYA VENKATARAMAN - Mother: Saranya Krishnakumar.

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INBRIEF



Run to raise awareness about polio held in Besant Nagar

The Rotary Club of United Chennai organised its annual marathon to create awareness about polio in Besant Nagar on Sunday. The marathon was held in two categories – 2 km and 5 km – on the theme “Run to End Polio” and saw more than 750 participants. Flagging off the marathon, D. Devendran, Governor for Rotary International District 3233, said the Rotary International’s PolioPlus programme was instrumental in making India a polio-free nation.



Training on innovate waste management practices held

A training programme on innovative solid waste management practices was conducted at the Ripon Buildings for cleanliness management committee coordinators from the 211 Corporation schools in all 15 zones of the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC). Coordinators were instructed to organise awareness programmes for students on third Wednesday every month.

How an NGO’s initiative is helping shape children’s early development in villages

Initiated in 2014 in 5 villages in Gummidipoondi, Bala Mandir Research and Resource Centre’s programme sought to raise awareness among parents about brain development; today, it supports over 2,500 parents and caregivers in 134 villages in Gummidipoondi and Ellapuram blocks in Tiruvallur

Meghna M.
CHENNAI

V. Menaka, a 29-year-old mother, was not completely aware that her two-year-old son was not as active as other children his age. “He used to keep to himself, wasn’t very playful, and always stayed close to me. But I thought that was normal,” she said.

However, her perspective changed when workers from the Bala Mandir Research and Resource Centre’s (BMRRC) Early Childhood Care and Development and Education (ECCDE) programme visited her.

“The staff briefed me about brain development and how crucial the early years are for a child to mingle and play with others. They told me there are various ways to help a child grow and learn, and that my role as a parent and the role of the community are both important. They also explained the importance of enrolling my child in the anganwadi,” she said.

Ms. Menaka, a resident of Lachivakkam in Tiruvallur district, said that months later, she witnessed her son playing



Crucial care: A staff member of the Early Childhood Care and Development and Education programme, which ropes in women from local villages, engaging with children. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

with other children at the anganwadi, which made her very happy. The child, who is now six years old, has been enrolled in Class 1 at a private school and is thriving. “He now makes friends easily and is eager to go to school,” she added.

Ms. Menaka’s sentiments were echoed by other parents who have benefited from the research centre’s ECCDE programme. Initiated in 2014 in five villages in Gummidipoondi, with assistance from Michelin Tyres, the programme sought to raise

awareness among parents about child and brain development.

“At the outset, anganwadis existed primarily as centres for nutrition for pregnant and lactating mothers. Later, the concept of early childhood care and development was introduced. Rural residents were initially hesitant to send their children there,” said Bindu R., director, BMRRC.

The ECCDE programme discusses brain development, noting that 25% of it occurs at birth and the re-

maining development takes place during the first six years of a child’s life. “We must make use of this small window for the child’s development,” she added.

A needs assessment was conducted in 2014, as anganwadi workers were overworked. Later, in association with the Integrated Child Development Services, we trained staff to work with anganwadi teachers to ensure that children are adequately stimulated,” Ms. Bindu said.

The BMRRC also deve-

loped training and introductory materials for staff as well as parents. The materials gave parents an understanding of the concept of SPRUC – namely, sense of self, physical development, relationships, understanding, and communication.

The activities and developmental needs change as a child grows, and the material outlines the kinds of activities parents can take up to engage the child – from building self-confidence to encouraging outdoor play and responsibility.

The staff, who are usually women from local villages, are trained in these concepts. They conduct activities at anganwadis in line with the curriculum. Further, during home visits, they interact with pregnant women and their families about the need to keep expectant mothers happy, provide them with nutritious food, and ensure regular check-ups.

“The staff explain to parents what child and brain development are. Parents often don’t understand how important it is to spend time with their children and engage them in simple activities. Everybo-

dy knows what to do with children, but they don’t always know why they are doing it, why it is important, or how it contributes to a child’s development,” Ms. Bindu said.

Training sessions

The programme personnel train anganwadi staff in the mornings and afternoons and conduct door-to-door visits for non-anganwadi children, their parents, pregnant women, postnatal mothers, and others caring for children. Additionally, community programmes are held every three months, along with parenting sessions conducted with women self-help groups.

Today, the programme has been expanded to 134 villages in Gummidipoondi and Ellapuram blocks, Tiruvallur. Over 2,500 parents and caregivers are supported each year, and 132 women staff members have been employed in these villages.

An anganwadi teacher from Lachivakkam said that admissions to her centre increased recently. “It is great to have more help in teaching the children,” she said, referring to the ECCDE staff.

CBSE schools set to face new format as Class 10 Board exams begin tomorrow

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Class 10 students of CBSE schools in the city are set to face the new format of two Board exams this year, as they prepare to take the Board exams starting Tuesday.

“There is no difference in the preparation of our students, as it is compulsory for them to write the first set of examinations. We completed our portions in November, giving them ample time to prepare for the upcoming exams,” said Lakshmi Prabh, principal, Prasan Vidya Mandir.

Last year, CBSE an-

The second set of exams will be held in May once the results of the first set of exams are declared

nounced that the Class 10 Board exams would be held twice from the academic year 2025-26, giving its students a chance to improve their scores.

The first set of exams would take place in February, and once the results are declared, the second set of exams will be held in May.

Students who wish to take up the second-set exams can register through

their school after the results are declared. They can take the second set of exams in any three subjects, except for language.

“It is purely for aspirational reasons... Students who want to improve their scores can definitely take up the second set of exams. It will only build self-esteem,” said Revathy Parameswaran, principal, P.S. Senior Secondary School, Mylapore.

However, teachers say the Class 10 scores do not have much of an impact on the student’s future studies. “As they should be accommodated in the same school in their preferred choice of stream as per the

CBSE’s instructions, the concept of two-Board exams is not necessary. In Class XII, there would be a need [for good scores], but otherwise, the students are assured of a seat in their school,” Ms. Lakshmi said.

Noting that while the schools in the city are prepared for any outcome, principal of KRM Public School D.P. Sivasakti Balan said they left it to the students and parents to make a call on taking the second set of exams.

“The parents and students have been briefed. The only worry is regarding the teachers’ availability as they lose their time twice over,” he added.

On Galentine’s Day, young women meet to celebrate, forge friendships

Sahana Mira S.
CHENNAI

On the eve of Valentine’s Day, women celebrate their female friendships on Galentine’s Day, a made-up holiday inspired by the American sitcom *Parks and Recreation*. But it’s clearly not confined to the West, because Chennai saw a flurry of Galentine’s Day gatherings this weekend.

Dyutika S., a full-time photographer, curated one such event in the city, where women aged 19 to 27 came with their “girl pals”. “We had a canvas painting session and wrote handwritten letters to each



A woman making a bouquet at an event organised by Social Age.

other on pink postcards, while sharing pastries.

“A couple of years ago, I did not even know about this concept of Galentine’s Day. But this year, it seems to have picked up momentum, and women in their 20s are far more interested

in it,” Ms. Dyutika said.

She added that many may be curious about attending such gatherings but hesitate because they lack company, so the event provided a space for strangers to form platonic friendships too.

Kriya, who runs Social Age, a community platform that focuses on curating social experiences, says many women who are single or those navigating long-distance relationships must not feel left out while the city celebrates love.

The Social Age’s Girl Gang Project’s celebration was attended by women aged 24 to 32. “I want women to enjoy Valentine’s Day even while being single, celebrating themselves and recognising their female friendships,” Ms. Kriya said.

She added that many millennial women in the city are seeking spaces to form potential friendships.

Lack of proper feed affects milk production in Tamil Nadu; Karnataka does better, show data

Deepa H. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Over the past seven years, the daily milk production per cross-breed cow has remained almost static in the State, at a little over 7 kg.

Between 2018 and 2025, the total daily milk yield from one cross-breed cow has hovered around 7.1 kg. It saw only minimal fluctuation – from as low as only 7.03 kg in 2023-24 to a high of just 7.84 kg in 2024-25, as per the 2025 Basic Animal Husbandry (BAH) statistics.

Farmers, many of whom sell milk to the Tamil Nadu Cooperative Milk Producers’ Federation (Aavin), cite lack of proper feed.

“Our cows need 400 gm of concentrate feed (containing protein, fibre, vitamins and minerals) to produce a litre of milk,” said A.P. Gunasekaran, a veterinarian.

“This is apart from the concentrate feed, dry fodder, and green grass needed for the animal when it does not produce milk. Farmers



Between 2018 and 2025, the total daily milk yield from one cross-breed cow has remained almost static, at a little over 7 kg. Farmers say such cows can produce up to 10 litres of milk a day. FILE PHOTO

have to spend ₹300 as feed and fodder per animal. But as they are unable to spend so much, cows that can produce up to 10 litres of milk a day are producing only around seven litres,” he added.

M.G. Rajendran, secretary, Tamil Nadu Milk Producers’ Welfare Association, pointed out that dairy farmers also had to spend on la-

bour, vaccinations, and treatments.

“In neighbouring Karnataka, where cross-bred cattle produce 10.71 kg of milk/day/animal, the government provides a subsidy of ₹5 a litre to farmers. Recently, the government announced that the subsidy would increase to ₹7 a litre. In that State, toned milk is sold at ₹46 a litre enabling the go-

vernment to pay the farmer well. However, that is not the case in Tamil Nadu. We get a subsidy of ₹3 per litre and milk is sold at ₹40 a litre,” he said.

Dip in fodder acreage

According to BAH statistics, Tamil Nadu has lost area under fodder crops, while Karnataka has improved its coverage. In 2018-19, Tamil

Nadu had 48,000 hectares under fodder crops. This fell to 35,000 hectares in 2025. In Karnataka, it went up from 71,000 hectares to 90,000 hectares during the same period.

A milk industry expert said that Aavin was started based on the Amul model. “The Karnataka federation studied Tamil Nadu’s model and implemented that. Now they have overtaken us in terms of production.” Earlier, Aavin used to provide subsidised veterinarian services. That has stopped now. Without making efforts to produce more milk, Aavin continues to create infrastructure to process milk, he said.

During the last Budget, the milk major had the capacity to process around 50 lakh litres of milk. At present, Aavin procures only 30 lakh litres to 35 lakh litres of milk per day. “If Aavin needs to survive and thrive for the sake of the over nine lakh milk pouring farmers, the Amul model needs to be revived,” he added.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

Shri Sunil Mitra, IAS passed away in Kolkata on Jan 12th 2026. Fondly remembered by family and friends.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES



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Son-in-law: P.Rajavarmen, B.Tech,

Grandchildren: Riddhi, Rishik,

Sister: Padmini Andavar, B.Sc.,

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CM writes to Modi on registered Sri Lankan Tamils living in India

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Sunday wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, placing four requests before the Centre for the welfare of Sri Lankan Tamils living in the State.

Mr. Stalin requested the Centre to rescind the administrative instructions that barred the consideration of citizenship applications from Sri Lankan Tamils.

He requested the issuance of an executive clarification waiving passport and visa requirements, where appropriate, for the purpose of citizenship or long-term visa applications, based on verified identity documentation issued by the Tamil Nadu government.

Mr. Stalin sought the delegating of appropriate powers to designated district-level authorities for streamlined processing, and requested the Union government to clarify the legal status of registered Sri Lankan Tamil nationals sheltered in India up to January 9, 2015.

Since 1983, successive governments of Tamil Nadu, with the support and concurrence of the Union government, have extended shelter, subsistence support, education, and healthcare to Sri Lankan Tamils, who fled ethnic conflict in Sri Lanka, he said. As of February 15, ap-

proximately 89,000 such individuals were residing in Tamil Nadu – a significant proportion of whom had lived in India for more than 30 years, and nearly 40% of whom were born on Indian soil, he noted.

“While the State has fulfilled its humanitarian responsibilities with commitment and compassion, these individuals remain in a state of prolonged legal uncertainty,” he said.

“I wish to state that the 2003 amendment to the Citizenship Act, which introduced the category of ‘illegal migrant’, has had the unintended consequence of retrospectively affecting those who entered India under extraordinary humanitarian circumstances and with the tacit approval of the Union government,” he said.

The administrative instructions issued in 1986 had constrained the acceptance of citizenship applications from this community, thereby creating barriers to resolution, he said. “However, recent policy developments – particularly the Immigration and Foreigners (Exemption) Order, 2025 – signal a constructive and humanitarian approach. A formal clarification that registered Sri Lankan Tamil nationals sheltered up to January 9, 2015 shall not be treated as ‘illegal migrants’ would provide much-needed legal certainty,” he added.

Congress bore the blame for DMK’s mistakes, says Tagore

Virudhunagar MP was indirectly referring to the United Progressive Alliance’s defeat in the 2014 Lok Sabha election; last week, Chief Minister M.K. Stalin ruled out power-sharing with allies

Udhav Naig
CHENNAI

The strains deepened in the DMK-Congress relationship on Sunday, with Congress leaders sharpening their attack on the ruling party.

At a meeting of the District Congress Committee in Madurai, B. Manickam Tagore, who won in a close election in 2024 from the Virudhunagar Lok Sabha constituency, said the Congress had to “carry the blame and answer for your [the DMK’s] mistakes”. He was indirectly referring to the corruption allegations against the DMK, which was part of the United Progressive Alliance government that was ousted in the 2014 Lok Sabha election.

Mr. Tagore criticised the DMK for not taking action against its Madurai North M.L.A., G. Thalapathi, who had questioned the Congress’s strength in Tamil Nadu. Mr. Tagore has been demanding that the Madurai North constituency be



When the DMK district secretary asks whether the Congress has enough workers to handle the booths, it becomes a problem

B. MANICKAM TAGORE
Congress MP

allotted to the Congress this time. He got a resolution passed at the meeting, seeking a share in power and more seats for the Congress. Last week, DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin ruled out power-sharing with allies.

“When the DMK district secretary [Mr. Thalapathi] asks disparagingly whether the Congress has enough workers to handle the booths, it becomes a problem. We carried the blame and answered for your mistakes,” Mr. Tagore said.

“Our leader Rahul Gandhi calls Chief Minister M.K. Stalin his ‘elder brother’. He expects the same respect to be given to the ordinary Congress work-

ers. His [Mr. Thalapathi’s] speech pained us. No action was taken against him, and he did not express regret either. So everyone has started talking in the same manner. If you don’t give us respect, we will speak in the same style,” he added.

To make matters worse, All India Professionals’ Congress president Praveen Chakravarthy, another critic of the DMK, cast doubts on the “winnability” of the DMK-led alliance just because the government credited ₹5,000 into the bank accounts of 1.31 crore women. “The Magalir Urimai Thittam is an excellent welfare scheme. Its implementation is commendable. However, it

would be superstitious to believe that it alone will ensure victory in the election. In the past three years, of the nine major State governments that announced such schemes, only four won,” he said.

Reacting to these developments, Tamil Nadu Congress Committee president K. Selvaperunthagai said the AICC leadership had made it clear to the State leaders that nobody should make comments against the DMK or the alliance in Tamil Nadu. “If such comments are made despite the warning, we will have to see what action the AICC takes against them,” he said.

A member of the Congress seat-sharing committee said that as long as Mr. Tagore refrained from speaking against the alliance with the DMK, there shouldn’t be any issue.

Another senior leader said the District Congress Committee does not have the power to pass any resolution on the alliance. “Are they more powerful than the AICC,” he asked.



Chief Minister M.K. Stalin releasing a souvenir at the International Vallalar Conference held in Chennai on Sunday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Vallalar celebrations will be held for three days every year: Stalin

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Sunday announced that the birth anniversary of Vallalar will be celebrated for three days every year.

He was speaking at the inauguration of a day-long International Vallalar Conference, organised by the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments (HR&CE) Department, on land belonging to the Ekambaranathar Temple in Kilpauk.

Research centre

He also announced the establishment of a centre for research on the saint in Chennai. It would come up at the HR&CE Department headquarters in Nungam-

bakkam. The announcement followed a request made by industrialist B.K. Krishnaraj Vanavarayar, who also praised the government for having organised an event to commemorate Vallalar on a grand scale.

The Chief Minister said Vallalar’s book, titled *Spiritual Alchemy*, would be brought out by the HR&CE Department, and Vallalar Annadhanam Centres would be established in Mettukuppam, Karunguzhi, and Marudhur.

Mr. Stalin unveiled a board with a new name – Vallalar High Road – for Thiruvottiyur High Road in north Chennai, and inaugurated the completed portions of the Vallalar International Centre in Vadalur.

‘No alliance capable of opposing DMK-led front has emerged’

The Hindu Bureau
CUDDALORE

VCK president Thol. Thirumavalavan on Sunday said no qualified alliance capable of opposing the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance has been formed yet in Tamil Nadu.

Addressing the media in Chidambaram, he claimed that the AIADMK alliance was fragmented, and was struggling to unite its leaders.

He expressed confidence that the people of Tamil Nadu will extend their massive support to the DMK-led alliance in the upcoming Assembly election. “The support has been growing due to the introduction of numerous welfare schemes. This alliance has been functioning since 2017, and people will support us,” he said.

Referring to the ongoing protest of Annamalai University teachers, Mr. Thirumavalavan called upon the State government to hold talks with them and fulfil their demands.

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INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY, CHENNAI - 38

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INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY, CHENNAI - 38

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1.	2026377212130	Proposed lifeline arrangements in Shop-30, 30A, 54, dispatch Shed and DPRS shed in Furnishing Division.	5.39 Crores	13.03.2026 @ 10:30 Hrs.

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INBRIEF



NLCIL signs MoU on thermal, renewable energy projects

NLC India Ltd. (NLCIL) has inked a memorandum of understanding with National Aluminium Company (NALCO), a Navaratna Central Public Enterprise (CPSE) under the Ministry of Mines, to strengthen collaboration in the development of thermal and renewable energy projects. The MoU was signed in the presence of NLCIL Chairman and Managing Director Prasanna Kumar Motupalli, and Director (Projects and Technical), NALCO, Jagdish Arora. According to the NLCIL, the MoU provides a structured framework for cooperation in the proposed 1,200 MW Thermal Captive Power Project and renewable energy development.

Five persons killed in accident near Vaippar in Thoothukudi

Five persons, including two children, were killed when the motorcycle they travelled on collided with a van near Vaippar in Thoothukudi district on Sunday. The police identified the deceased as Gurusamy, 40, his sister Lakshmi, 48, and his brother's sons Sumithran, 3, and Mugilan, 5, all from Pallakulam. The fifth victim was a woman estimated to be around 40 years, whose identity was yet to be ascertained, as she was known only to Gurusamy and Lakshmi. All five were travelling from Kulathur towards Pallakulam. The Kulathur police registered a case and secured van driver Pachakili, 56, of Thoothukudi.

Second edition of T.N. Economic Survey likely to be out today

The govt. will present the Interim Budget tomorrow; the State Planning Commission has prepared the survey with inputs from Finance Dept.

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government is likely to release its second Economic Survey on Monday, a day before the Interim Budget is presented in the Assembly for 2026-27.

The State Planning Commission has prepared the document, mainly with inputs from the Finance Department. Multiple persons have contributed articles to the survey, which may have a chapter on women's participation.

Estimated growth rate
The Centre has not yet made public the estimated growth rate for the current year (2025-26).

From 2012-13 to 2023-24, Tamil Nadu's economy grew at an average real rate of 6.37%, compared with the national average of 6.1%. During 2024-25, its Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) registered a growth of 11.2%, according to the Reserve Bank of India's *Handbook Of Statistics*



During 2024-25, Tamil Nadu's GSDP registered a growth of 11.2%, according to the Reserve Bank of India's 'Handbook of Statistics on Indian States'. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

In the last 20-odd years, the State's economic (real) growth rate was, on a majority of the occasions, higher than that of the national average

On *Indian States*. The Economic Survey, which was released by the Union Finance Ministry a few weeks ago, placed the country's real economic

growth at 7.4%. So, the State's figure is expected to be higher than this, though the degree of difference may vary. Eventually, it may turn out to be in double digits, but it remains to be seen whether the State will surpass the record of the year 2024-25, an observer says.

In the past 20-odd years, the State's economic (real) growth rate was, on a majority of occasions, higher than that of the national average.

EPS hits back at CM, says AIADMK is a self-respecting party

The Hindu Bureau
ERODE

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami on Sunday rejected Chief Minister M.K. Stalin's allegation that his party was functioning as a "slave" or a "branch" of the BJP, and asserted that the AIADMK operated independently.

Addressing a public meeting at Ariyappampalayam in the Bhavanisagar Assembly constituency as part of his Statewide tour, he said the AIADMK was a "self-respecting party" that stood on its own. "The AIADMK is not a slave to anyone," he said, adding that the DMK, on the contrary, was dependent on the Congress. He accused Mr. Stalin of indulging in false propaganda and referred to a past 'raid' at Anna Arivalayam, the DMK headquarters, while alliance discussions were under way with the Congress. "That is slavery, and even if Mr. Stalin deliberately spreads slander, it will not succeed," he said.

He pointed out that two months ago, Mr. Stalin had claimed that no party was willing to join hands with the AIADMK. "Alliances should form naturally. Now the NDA, led by the AIADMK, stands strong,"



AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami addressing a meeting in Erode on Sunday. M. GOVARTHAN

he said, alleging that the DMK alliance was witnessing internal discord.

Mr. Palaniswami accused Mr. Stalin of running a government focused on publicity rather than governance.

Recalling developments following the demise of former Chief Minister J. Jayalalithaa, he said the AIADMK had weathered internal challenges with the support of party cadre and he had been elected Chief Minister by a majority of MLAs. Drawing a comparison between their political trajectories, Mr. Palaniswami said he had risen through hard work, "whereas Mr. Stalin became the Chief Minister owing to the legacy of his father, the late DMK leader M. Karunanidhi".

SIR: final electoral rolls to be released on Feb. 23

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The final electoral roll in Tamil Nadu will be published on February 23 following the completion of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise, Chief Electoral Officer Archana Patnaik said on Sunday.

Following an order of the Supreme Court of India, the Election Commission (EC), on January 30 said they had instructed that the list of the names of the persons figuring in the category of "logical discrepancies" would be displayed at the gram panchayat bhavans, public places, and taluka/sub-division, including the ward offices in urban areas.

The EC had also instructed that the persons likely to be affected under the category were permitted to submit their documents/objections in-person or through their authorised representative, which may include booth-level agents, within 10 days from the date of displaying the list of persons falling in the category of logical discrepancy, along with the brief reason of discrepancy. "Accordingly, the lists were put up and objections were invited for the next 10 days," the release said.

MMK wants to contest five Assembly seats: Jawahirullah

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI



M.H. Jawahirullah

Manithaneyya Makkal Katchi president M.H. Jawahirullah said on Sunday that the party wanted to contest five Assembly seats as a part of the DMK-led alliance. He also urged other alliance partners to give Muslims more representation while distributing ticket to candidates. The MMK had contested two Assembly seats – Manapparai and Papanasam – in 2021 and won both as a part of the DMK alliance.

Speaking to presspersons after the party's special general body meeting in Chennai, Mr. Jawahirullah said the demand for "share in power", which was being consistently made by the Congress in Tamil Nadu, "will not be applicable to Tamil Nadu".

"We also resolved [in the special general body meeting] to seek five Assembly constituencies for the MMK as a part of the DMK alliance," he said, and appealed to the MMK cadre to ensure a "Dravidian Model 2.0" government is formed in Tamil Nadu.

"The present government must continue and Dravidian Model 2.0 must blossom in Tamil Nadu. The DMK government has satisfied many of our long-

standing demands: Chief Minister M.K. Stalin met the minority communities – Christians and Muslims – at the Secretariat and has taken a number of steps to resolve their issues. Minority students were given an education loan of ₹5 lakh and teachers working in minority-run institutions were given recognition. Graveyards for Muslims and Christians have been set up in corporations. The mandate to obtain 'No Objection Certificate' to build mosques and churches has been done away with," he said.

Mr. Jawahirullah added: "At a time when the representation of Muslims (in Parliament and Assembly) has reduced in India, the political parties in the alliance should give appropriate representation to Muslims."

Sasikala plans to continue consultations with followers to finalise strategy for Assembly polls

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

V.K. Sasikala, former interim general secretary of the AIADMK and former Chief Minister Jayalalithaa's aide, who began meeting her followers early last week, will continue her consultations this week.

The purpose of Ms. Sasikala's ongoing discussion is to finalise her camp's strategy for the 2026 Assembly election. She has planned to hold discussion up to Wednesday, says her follower who is a former legislator.

At present, she has no place in the AIADMK, though she claims she remains the general secretary of the party. The follower of her camp says it is up to her to take a call shortly. This may take place before the birth anni-

versary of Jayalalithaa on February 24, he adds.

Interactions' purpose
Explaining the purpose of the interactions, one of her supporters says the idea is to impress upon Ms. Sasikala that her group should not keep itself out of the Assembly election, unlike in 2021, when she chose to step aside from contesting the election.

Besides, the affairs of the parent party "are not being run" along the lines of the organisation's founder M.G. Ramachandran and his successor Jayalalithaa's ideals. "This is why we want to enter the electoral fray and mark our presence," the member of the Sasikala camp observes.

As for Ms. Sasikala, who was in February 2017 convicted in a corruption case



V.K. Sasikala

and jailed for a four-year term, the period of disqualification from contesting elections continues, and therefore, she will not be able to contest the polls this year.

The disqualification period will come to an end only early next year.

When her nephew T.T.V. Dhinakaran launched the Amma Makkal Munnetra

Kazhagam (AMMK) in 2018, Ms. Sasikala was named the general secretary of the new party. At the time, she was serving her sentence in a jail in Bengaluru. A year later, Mr. Dhinakaran became the general secretary and stated publicly that his aunt would continue with litigation for gaining control of the AIADMK.

Palaniswami's stance
Even as he has joined hands with the Dravidian major, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami has refused to accommodate both Ms. Sasikala and former coordinator of the party and ex-Chief Minister O. Panneerselvam in the alliance.

To a question on whether the group's presence in the electoral scene will have an impact on the

prospects of the AIADMK and its allies in the polls, he recalls that in his home district of Tiruvallur, the AIADMK and its partners had lost in all the 10 constituencies by substantial margins.

This showed how the party had become "weak," and it is to "correct this situation" that the group was contemplating taking part in the poll.

To another question as to whether the group would align itself with Mr. Panneerselvam, who met Ms. Sasikala at Pasumpon last year during the birth anniversary of Forward Bloc leader U. Muthuramalinga Thevar, and a faction owing allegiance to the Pattali Makkal Katchi's founder S. Ramadoss, he says all options will be considered before she finalises her stand.

PIL plea moved in Madras HC against eight provisions of VB-G RAM G Act

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

A public interest litigation petition has been filed in the Madras High Court challenging eight provisions of the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act (VB-G RAM G Act) of 2025, which had replaced the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) of 2005.

The PIL plea is expected to be listed for hearing before the first Division Bench of Chief Justice Manindra Mohan Shrivastava and Justice G. Arul Murugan this week. Seventy-one-year-old advocate T. Sivagnanasambandan of T. Nagar in Chennai had filed the case through his counsel on record M.L. Ravi. In his affidavit, the litigant stated the MGNREGA had been one of the world's largest social secur-

ity initiatives which had been studied and evaluated intensively by multiple organisations. All those studies had recognised its transformative effects on the weaker sections of society, he claimed.

"The MGNREGA exempted State governments from most of the financial burden since the cost sharing ratio between the Centre and the States was 90:10. But now, as per the new Act, the cost-sharing ratio is 90:10 only for northeastern and himalayan States and 60:40 for others," he complained.

Similarly, the MGNREGA granted greater autonomy to village panchayats, in accordance with the 73rd Constitutional amendment, by making them the principal implementation authority but the VB-G RAM G Act had bid "good bye" to those constitutional guarantees given to panchayats, the

petitioner lamented. Claiming the MGNREGA and other beneficial legislations such as the National Food Security Act of 2013 had prevented hunger deaths during COVID-19, the petitioner said: "The demolition of MGNREGA now will have a catastrophic impact on crores of people across rural India."

He contended Sections 3(1), 4(5), 5(1), 6(2), 22, 30, 34 and 37 of the VB-G RAM G Act were unjust, anti-federal and unconstitutional since they were against the rights guaranteed under Articles 14 (right to equality), 16 (right to equality of opportunity) and 21 (right to life) of the Constitution.

Section 3(4) requires the State governments to frame a scheme consistent with the provisions of VB-G RAM G Act within six months from its commencement and Section 4(5) states that the Centre shall determine the State-wise nor-

mative allocation of work for each financial year, based on objective parameters.

Section 5(1) of the Act requires the State governments to provide every household, whose adult members volunteer to do unskilled manual work, not less than 125 days of guaranteed employment in a financial year but insists that the beneficiaries must be selected from rural areas notified by the Centre. Section 6(2) of VB-G RAM G Act mandates the State governments to notify in advance, a period aggregating to 60 days in a financial year covering the peak agricultural seasons of sowing and harvesting, during which works under the Act should not be undertaken to facilitate adequate availability of agricultural labour.

For the full story, visit: <https://newsth.live/VBGRAMG>

Chess classes to be introduced in tribal schools to improve learning outcomes

N. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

In an effort to strengthen academic outcomes among tribal students, the Tribal Welfare Department is set to introduce chess as a learning tool in Government Tribal Residential Schools and Eklavya Model Residential Schools across the State under its administrative control.

The initiative will begin in the next academic year. The department has initiated steps to train physical education teachers to integrate chess into classroom learning.

Recently, the department, in association with FIDE Chess in Education (CIE) and Emmanuel Chess Centre, organised a three-day workshop at Madras Christian College for teachers from these schools.

A total of 42 teachers from tribal schools participated in the workshop. Ri-



Honing skills: Students playing chess at the Government Tribal Residential Higher Secondary School at Karumandurai in Salem.

ta Atkins, Women's International Master, and Ebinezer Joseph, Senior Lead Instructor of the FIDE CIE Commission, introduced the structure and educational value of chess to the teachers.

Last year, the department gave training in chess to 22 teachers.

Official sources said the use of chess to support learning outcomes of students in tribal schools is

not entirely new. In some schools, teachers have voluntarily introduced the game to improve academic engagement of students.

M. Thangadurai, a Physical Education teacher at the Government Tribal Residential School in Arnoothumalai in Salem district, has been conducting chess classes every Monday evening.

He said that after the 44th Chess Olympiad held

in Chennai in 2022, he began teaching chess to tribal students.

The school also organised in-house chess competitions. He said he observed improvement in students' concentration and thinking ability after they began playing chess.

Officials said the department has now decided to train more teachers and expand the initiative in a structured manner. G. Laxmi Priya, Secretary, Adi Dravidar and Tribal Welfare, said the objective is to make chess a means of learning and to improve students' cognitive ability. She said the department has planned to provide special focus on strengthening chess clubs in these schools from the next academic year.

It also plans to conduct inter-school competitions and assess students' learning outcomes following the introduction of chess.



Poll sop The ECI's proven bias on model code seems to have forced T.N.'s hand

When welfare measures to uplift under-privileged sections are deployed as a political tool in an election year it raises the question whether it is an instance of affirmative action or merely a cynical device that plays out as a poll-eve incentive. Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin's surgical action of crediting ₹5,000 each in the bank accounts of over 1.31 crore women beneficiaries of the *Kalaig-nar Magalir Urimai Thittam* (KMUT), triggers exactly this uncomfortable thought. The KMUT, in operation since September 2023, envisages a monthly direct transfer of ₹1,000 “rights grant” recognising the dignity and contribution of women heads of families. Notably 32% of its beneficiaries are SC/STs. Citing political and legal apprehensions that the scheme, which is being projected as a rights-based social entitlement and not as a populist freebie, could be suspended prior to the Assembly election, Mr. Stalin chose to give it the force of a political multiplier by disbursing ₹3,000 each for February, March and April in one go. He also introduced a novel “summer assistance” of ₹2,000. Mr. Stalin's concerns about the possibility of the scheme being stopped after the announcement of the election schedule are not unwarranted. The Election Commission of India (ECI) has not been consistent in its interpretation of what constitutes a violation of the Model Code of Conduct. A recent precedent for voter incentivisation emerged during the 2025 Bihar elections, when the JD(U)-BJP coalition deposited ₹10,000 each to one crore women under the *Mukhyamantri Mahila Rojgar Yojana*. The ECI turned a blind eye to what was widely seen as an attempt to buy votes for the ruling coalition with funds from the exchequer. Previously, in Tamil Nadu, the ECI had suspended a cash support scheme for farmers (2004) and distribution of free colour television sets (2011). Adoption of double standards by the ECI when it comes to adjudication of such issues has become common. The overall outgo from the exchequer on a single day exceeded ₹6,550 crore including an unplanned expenditure of ₹2,620 crore for the summer component. Offering cash benefits through government schemes on poll eve does not guarantee absolute voter loyalty. But it certainly places the ruling party in the pole position to politically leverage the exchequer. Unless the ECI plays fair in the implementation of the model code, it is difficult to fault such measures by those in power. At least, in the case of Tamil Nadu, this was an on-going scheme since 2023, and only the newly added summer assistance raises a political stink. But, in the context of what the BJP-led coalition did in Bihar, this is innocuous.

Hot air Donald Trump is trying to turn back the clock on environmental issues

As part of his continuing assault on science, U.S. President Donald Trump revoked a foundational guideline of the American environment regulator that allowed it to control the transportation sector's emission of greenhouse gases. The repeal of the ‘endangerment finding’ was the final, formal blow following a series of actions by the U.S.'s Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) in weakening Obama-era administration fuel economy and greenhouse gas (GHG) standards for vehicle model years 2021-26 and loosening fuel efficiency norms. The ‘endangerment finding’ emerged after the US Supreme Court's 2007 decision, in *Massachusetts vs EPA*, which held that greenhouse gases qualify as “air pollutants” and required the EPA to determine whether they endanger public health or welfare. In December 2009, the EPA concluded that six greenhouse gases – including carbon dioxide and methane – “may reasonably be anticipated to endanger” health and welfare, drawing heavily on assessments by the IPCC and U.S. scientific bodies. The EPA's action had a seismic impact on the American automotive industry, setting in motion the first federal greenhouse gas standards, set in 2010, for cars and light trucks (2012-16), later extended through 2025. Manufacturers accelerated fuel-efficiency improvements, invested in hybrid systems, lightweight materials, and, eventually, battery-electric vehicles. Regulatory credit markets emerged, benefiting firms such as Tesla, Inc. and resulting in the popularity of electric vehicles globally, including in India. Though indirect, the stricter greenhouse gas emission norms also influenced a world-wide shift away from the ‘small car’ to the mid-sized Sport Utility Vehicles (SUV) with car markers improving the SUV's emissions profile. Mr. Trump seems to believe that doing away with the EPA regulations will revive America's ‘gas guzzler’ era, boost American manufacturing jobs, and somehow tie in with his administration's rediscovery of Venezuelan oil. These are pipedreams. Auto-manufacturing production lines today are optimised around electrification, hybridisation and emissions controls. With China dominating most of the production value chain, it is unlikely that auto-manufacturers, who have invested over a multi-decadal horizon into clean vehicles – and with the intention to export to countries where emissions norms are only getting stricter by the day – will change tack to a regress. At best, the norms will be a speed bump to electric vehicle rollout and could win Mr. Trump some brownie points with his voter base. The real danger lies in automakers in India citing such regulation as a pretext to weaken fuel efficiency standards. Although India's standards do not yet connect climate goals with cars, the domestic automotive sector should view them as a lodestar.

India's post-Independence service rules were designed to ensure stability through generalist administrators – an approach that was essential for nation-building. However, governance has since become increasingly shaped by science, technology, and environmental challenges. As scientists joined government service, they remained governed by rules created for a different era. This mismatch has limited the effective integration of scientific expertise into policymaking. Unlike many advanced countries with dedicated scientific cadres, India lacks a specialised framework for scientific governance, making the case for separate scientific service rules increasingly compelling.

A paradox – administrator and scientist Civil services recruitment is highly competitive, reflecting the rigour of the administrative system. Scientific careers, however, follow an equally demanding but different path – drawing from a smaller, highly specialised pool shaped by years of advanced education, research and peer review rather than a single examination. Within government, administrators receive structured training aligned with governance roles, while scientists are often placed in diverse technical portfolios without comparable frameworks for role-specific training, career progression, or clear alignment of authority and professional safeguards.

Scientific inputs in policymaking are often commissioned for immediate needs – such as legal cases or regulatory decisions – making research time-bound and narrow. A stronger approach would support continuous, long-term research that anticipates emerging challenges, allowing decisions to be guided by evidence and foresight rather than urgency.

Until science becomes a regular partner in governance rather than a reactive tool, its full potential to improve policy and public trust will remain underused. Thus, most scientific research is not specifically designed to improve the effectiveness of existing policies or to meet the future needs of countries in shaping policy change.

As India's responsibilities expanded into technically intensive sectors, environmental protection, climate change, oceans and coasts, public health, disaster management, nuclear safety, biotechnology, space science, and artificial intelligence, scientists became indispensable to government functioning.

Yet, instead of creating a distinct institutional framework that was suited to scientific work, scientists were largely absorbed into the existing administrative system. They continue to be governed by conduct rules, appraisal mechanisms, and hierarchies that were originally



P. Ragavan
is a coastal ecosystem researcher with 15 years of research and field expertise on mangroves and seagrass

A dedicated scientific cadre is needed to strengthen governance as science, technology and environmental challenges become central

designed for general administrative functions. Over time, this has limited the ability of scientists to exercise their professional role fully within governance structures. While organisations such as the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research, the Indian Council of Agricultural Research and a few others have separate rules for recruitment, assessment, and promotion, they continue to be bound by the Central Civil Services (Conduct) Rules, 1964, a framework designed primarily for administrative governance rather than scientific independence.

Administrative rules are not neutral Service rules shape behaviour and culture. While civil service rules stress discipline and neutrality, scientific work requires questioning assumptions and presenting evidence even when it challenges policy. Without frameworks that accommodate this, scientific inputs remain advisory rather than fully integrated into decision-making.

Scientific progress depends on continuous inquiry, testing of evidence, and honest assessment of risks and uncertainties. In governance, this translates into the ability to flag ecological risks, technological limitations, or long-term consequences in a transparent manner. When scientists are unable to formally record or communicate such assessments within institutional processes, their role risks becoming symbolic rather than substantive. Science that cannot question policy is not science. It is a decoration. Effective governance requires mechanisms that allow scientific assessments to be placed on record, even while final policy choices remain with elected authorities.

Many countries, which includes France, Germany, Japan, the United Kingdom and the United States have created distinct scientific cadres within government, with tailored service rules, career paths, and professional protections. These systems strengthen governance by ensuring transparent, independent scientific input into policymaking. For example, U.S. Scientific Integrity Policies protect scientists from political interference, require transparent documentation of advice, and prevent suppression or alteration of research findings, ensuring that policies are guided by credible evidence rather than political convenience.

India's situation is distinctive. Despite strong scientific institutions and highly trained professionals, government scientists often have limited institutional authority relative to their expertise. Their inputs may not always carry formal weight in decision-making processes, particularly in technically complex sectors. This can result in cautious communication, limited documentation of uncertainty, and an over-reliance on science during crises rather than as a continuous input into policy formulation. A

governance system that does not fully utilise its scientific capacity risks long-term policy weaknesses. India's aspirations, to be a leader in climate action, environmental stewardship, public health, and technology, require institutions that value scientific evidence alongside administrative efficiency. What is needed is not additional committees or ad-hoc advisory bodies, but structural reform that clearly defines the role of scientists within governance and provides appropriate institutional safeguards.

The creation of an Indian scientific services, or ISS, offers a constructive way forward. The ISS could function as a permanent, all-India scientific cadre working alongside existing civil services. Scientists would be recruited through rigorous national-level selection and peer evaluation and placed within ministries and regulatory institutions as integral participants in decision-making. Separate scientific service rules would protect professional integrity, enable transparent recording of scientific assessments, and clarify the distinction between scientific advice and policy decisions. The ISS is not intended to replace administrative systems, but to complement them. Administrators ensure coordination and execution; scientists contribute evidence, risk assessment, and long-term perspective.

A potential framework A possible structure for an ISS could include specialised cadres such as the Indian Environmental and Ecological Service, Indian Climate and Atmospheric Service, Indian Water and Hydrological Service, Indian Marine and Ocean Services, Indian Public Health and Biomedical Service, Indian Disaster Risk and Resilience Service, Indian Energy and Resources Service, Indian Science and Technology Policy Service, Indian Agricultural and Food Systems Service, and Indian Regulatory Science Service.

India has built strong scientific institutions. The next step is to integrate scientific expertise more directly into governance structures. The need for an ISS is no longer theoretical. It is a practical and timely reform to strengthen evidence-based policymaking and build more resilient governance for the future.

Under the current political leadership, India is steadily moving beyond its colonial legacy and building a confident new India. In this spirit, an ISS would be a forward-looking reform – much like the transformation of the Indian Civil Service after Independence – strengthening a science-driven administrative system that is aligned with India's national aspirations and global ambitions .

The views expressed are personal

The UAE-India corridor is sparking a growth story



Badr Jafar
is Special Envoy of the United Arab Emirates Foreign Minister for Business and Philanthropy

The UAE-India corridor is driving growth, technology and strategic global expansion

confident long-term industrial commitments.

Investment is flowing with equal conviction in the other direction. DP World has committed an additional \$5 billion to Indian infrastructure, expanding its already extensive network of ports and logistics parks across the country. Emirates NBD's acquisition of a majority stake in RBL Bank represents the largest single foreign direct investment in Indian banking history. ADNOC has signed long-term LNG supply agreements with Indian Oil Corporation Ltd and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited worth billions of dollars. Mubadala has deployed over \$4 billion across Indian health care, renewables, and technology platforms. Abu Dhabi Investment Authority became the first sovereign wealth fund to establish a base in India's GIFT City.

It is for the long term What underpins all of this is trust built over decades, reinforced by human connections, and supported by a policy architecture – the CEPA, which eliminated tariffs on roughly 90% of tariff lines, the 2024 Bilateral Investment Treaty, and now a strategic defence partnership - that gives businesses the certainty to make long-term bets.

The ambition is now extending into third markets. Bharat Mart, currently under construction in the UAE, will serve as a wholesale hub for Indian goods targeting Africa, West Asia and Eurasia, aiming to help double India's exports to these regions. India and the UAE are also exploring joint digital infrastructure and capacity-building initiatives across Africa. The corridor is becoming a platform not just for bilateral exchange but also for global reach.

Artificial intelligence (AI) is emerging as the next major frontier for this corridor. India this week hosts the AI Impact Summit in New Delhi (February 16-20, 2026) – the first global AI summit held in the Global South. It is a powerful

statement of India's growing role in shaping how this technology develops and is governed. The UAE, which appointed the world's first Minister of State for AI back in 2017 and has invested heavily in AI infrastructure and research ever since, is a natural partner in this space. The UAE and India are already exploring cooperation on advanced computing capacity, data centres, and AI-driven innovation. In a technology that will reshape every sector of every economy, the countries that lead will not be those that build fastest alone, but those that build the smartest partnerships.

The next chapter India's global moment is here. As the world's fourth-largest economy, with GDP at around \$4 trillion, it is powered by entrepreneurial energy, manufacturing ambition, and digital infrastructure that are genuinely world-class. In conversations with Indian business leaders, there is one theme that is coming through consistently: the appetite to scale internationally has never been stronger. The question is no longer whether Indian enterprise will go global, but how effectively the right corridors can accelerate that journey.

This is also part of a wider realignment. The recent Delhi Declaration between India and Arab Foreign Ministers outlined an ambitious programme of cooperation across politics, economy, energy, technology, and security through 2028. The India-UAE corridor is at the vanguard of that broader convergence.

The UAE and India are demonstrating what becomes possible when two countries align policy, capital, and execution around a shared vision. The first \$100 billion came faster than anyone expected. The next chapter will be defined not by the numbers alone, but by how deeply their economies integrate – and how far that integration reaches.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

‘Welfare’ concerns
Pre-election welfare announcements targeted at specific voter groups, particularly when timed strategically close to election dates, raise important ethical and regulatory questions. This political template, pioneered during the tenure of former Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Ms. Jayalalithaa, and subsequently witnessed in several States — Odisha, Maharashtra,

Bihar and now Tamil Nadu and West Bengal — now appears to be shaping campaign strategies across the country. If such practices become the norm, they could blur the line between genuine welfare policy and electoral advantage. Therefore, it may be time for the Election Commission of India (ECI) to undertake a review of the Model Code of Conduct to ensure clarity, fairness, and a level playing field in

elections. Whether the ECI is prepared to address this evolving challenge remains to be seen.
S.R. Patnaik,
Bhubaneswar, Odisha

Microplastic warning
There is no doubt that the Madras High Court has delivered a significant and timely judgment (Tamil Nadu, “Water, salt, and sugar packs must carry warning on presence of micro, nanoplastics: Madras

HC”, February 15). By directing the Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare and the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) to require warning labels on packaged water, salt, and sugar regarding microplastic contamination, the High Court has taken an important step toward consumer awareness and public health protection in India. However, a crucial question remains. Who will

determine the permissible limits of microplastics in food products? Studies have detected worrying levels of microplastics even in seafood. Clear regulatory standards, backed by scientific assessment, are needed as time is running out.
H. Panicker,
Mulakuzha, Chengannur, Kerala

Linguistic concerns
India's linguistic diversity risks being undermined by

the growing use of Hindi in official names and central schemes. A recent example is the renaming of the Executive Enclave as “Seva Teerth”. This trend risks marginalising non-Hindi speakers and creating the impression of India moving toward a Hindi-only national identity.
Benci Jerald B.R.,
Chennai

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CM
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Trinamool's solo posture in Parliament is a strategy, not a snub to INDIA bloc

Congress questions impact of India-U.S. trade pact on agriculture, crop prices

Amit Shah accuses Rahul of spreading 'lies' on trade deals

India has agreed to stop buying Russian oil, says Rubio

Key Bill to be brought in second part of the Budget Session: Rijiju

Why two is better than one in a home loan

Santosh Agarwal

A co-applicant applies for a home loan along with the primary borrower and is equally liable for repayments. Usually, close family members, such as spouse, children and parents, can be added as co-applicants. Adding a co-applicant to your home loan not only improves your home loan eligibility, but also reduces the chances of home loan rejection due to reasons such as insufficient income or high EMI/NMI ratio.

The lender evaluates the income and credit profile of the co-applicant that can help you secure a lower interest rate, higher loan amount, better loan terms and individual tax benefits. Do note that the co-owner of the property has to be the co-applicant of the home loan, but a co-applicant need not necessarily be the co-owner of the property.

Chances of approval

If the primary applicant has a weak credit profile, adding a co-applicant with a strong credit profile increases the chances of approval of the loan application. Joint loan applications are considered less risky by the lenders since both applicants are equally responsible for EMI repayments. A co-applicant with a higher income and a strong credit score strengthens the loan application and reduces the chances of loan rejection.

Higher loan amount

Adding a co-applicant often increases the borrower's loan amount eligibility. Individuals having insufficient income can add their immediate family members with a strong credit profile as co-applicants and get approved for a higher loan amount. Lenders assess the combined income of the applicant and the co-applicant during the home loan evaluation process, thereby increasing their chances of availing a higher loan amount.

Lower interest rates

The combined credit profile of joint borrowers often makes them eligible for lower interest rates. Also, many lenders may offer an interest rate concession of 0.05% to women borrowers. Thus, adding a woman co-applicant to your home loan can help reduce the overall home loan cost.

Individual tax benefits

Home loan borrowers can claim a tax deduction of up to ₹1.5 lakh on principal repayment under Section 80C and up to ₹2 lakh on the repayment of interest component under Section 24b every financial year. If the co-applicant is also the co-owner of the property, he/she can avail the available tax benefits in accordance with their contribution towards the repayment. Thus, both the primary applicant and the co-borrower can jointly claim a total tax deduction of up to ₹7 lakh on the repayment of principal and interest component every year.

Most lenders usually require their applicants to be not more than 70-75 years old at the time of loan maturity. Therefore, individuals planning to avail a home loan at a later stage of life have higher chances of home loan rejection or getting a shorter repayment tenure. Adding a younger earning co-applicant, like children with income, with a strong credit profile to their home loan can increase their chances of home loan approval and help them get a longer tenure. A right co-applicant with a strong credit profile reduces the risk of outright home loan rejection for a primary applicant, who otherwise might not have qualified due to their inability to meet the eligibility criteria of various lenders on their own.

Any default or delay in loan repayment, however, adversely affects the credit score of not only the primary borrower but also the co-applicant, which in turn impacts the eligibility to avail loans and credit cards in future for both applicants.

(The writer is CEO of Paisabazaar)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



Little awareness: Most home-buyers are unaware that they can buy home loan insurance independently instead of plan offered by lender.

Demystifying home loan insurance for borrowers

Since the insurance is bundled with the loan, customers, who are typically presented with a single option, rarely compare alternatives or question whether the product is suited to their needs

CONDITIONS APPLY

Vivek Jain

It's no wonder that home loan borrowing in India is growing at a 14% pace, as per official data. Owning a home is one of the most sought-after dreams in India, especially for the middle class income group. But what usually follows this dream is taking a loan to fulfill it.

Most homebuyers in India are all too familiar with the usual drill that follows once you decide a buy a home.

Navigating the sky-high property prices has most of them knocking the doors at banks for a loan.

And once that happens, they are usually handed the bundled insurance deal along with the loan.

While there's no doubt that home loan insurance is a valuable product which protects homebuyers' largest liability if the borrower is no longer around, the way it is sold is often opaque and rigid.

Despite its importance, the product has remained poorly understood, rigidly structured and largely sold as an afterthought, bundled with loans, explained inadequately, and rarely revisited once signed.

As a result, many borrowers end up paying far more than necessary for protection they neither chose consciously nor fully understood.

This is precisely where the need for a more affor-



Premiums are significantly higher, partly due to distribution costs and GST. The plans often lack flexibility

dable and transparent alternative needs to begin.

The need for rethink

Historically, home loan insurance in India has been offered offline, often at the loan sanction stage, and sometimes even at disbursement stage. Borrowers are typically presented with a single option, with little clarity on pricing, premium structure or long-term cost implications. Since the insurance is bundled with the loan, customers rarely compare alternatives or question whether the product is suited to their needs.

The result is opacity on two fronts. First, premiums are significantly higher, partly due to distribution costs and the inclusion of GST.

Second, these plans often lack flexibility. Borrowers remain locked into long-term premium commitments even if the loan is prepaid or foreclosed early. In many cases, claim payouts are structured primarily to settle the lender's outstanding amount, leaving families with limited financial autonomy at a time of crisis.

In a market where borrowers have become increasingly cost-conscious



Borrowers remain locked into long-term premium commitments even if the loan is prepaid or foreclosed early

and choice-driven, this model feels out of step.

Modern solutions

In today's day and age, any financial product needs to be affordable and flexible with the policyholder firmly in control. Especially when it comes to long-tenure liabilities such as home loans, this is even more imperative.

That is because even small differences in prices compound significantly over time. Borrowers can look for premiums that reflect actual risk rather than a bundled product.

And most importantly, they want clarity on how much they are paying, what they are covered for, and who ultimately receives the claim benefit. This shift in expectations has opened the door for a more transparent, consumer-first approach to home loan protection.

Online home loan insurance addresses many of the structural limitations of traditional covers.

By moving to a direct-to-consumer model, these plans eliminate multiple layers of distribution cost. The absence of GST further reduces the overall premium outgo, making protection significantly more af-

fordable over long loan tenures.

To illustrate the difference, for a 30-year-old borrower with a ₹1 crore home loan over 20 years, traditional offline home loan insurance can result in a total premium outgo of nearly ₹6 lakh. An online home loan insurance plan for the same cover can cost close to ₹1.6 lakh over the same period. This translates into savings of up to 72%.

Beyond cost, flexibility is also key differentiator between online and offline plans. Online plans allow borrowers to align coverage with their outstanding loan, adjust protection as liabilities change, and foreclose loans without worrying about sunk insurance costs.

Awareness gap

Despite these advantages, awareness around online home loan insurance remains low.

Most home-buyers are unaware that they can buy home loan insurance independently instead of going for the plan offered by their lender. Others assume that life insurance automatically covers loan liabilities, without realising that mismatches in coverage or timing can leave families exposed.

This lack of awareness has meant that a large section of borrowers continue to overpay for protection or remain under-protected altogether.

(The writer is Chief Business Officer, Life Insurance, Policybazaar.com)

Buy, hold vs. market timing

THINKINVESTOR

Research shows the buy-and-hold returns strategy on investments are significantly higher than the actual returns of a market timer. This difference is referred to as behaviour gap.

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

You may be a buy-and-hold investor or a market timer. How did you feel about the sharp decline in silver ETF prices after they touched an all-time high? Did you regret not taking profit at higher levels? Or did you take profit only to see prices move up further? Let discuss trade-off between strategy of buy-and-hold and market timing.

The trade-off

Take an investment of ₹50,000. Its value slips by 20% in a year and rises by 20% the following year. The investment value at the end of the first year will be ₹40,000 and at the end of the second year it will be ₹48,000 resulting in a geometric return of -2.02%. However, the arithmetic return of zero (average of -20% and +20%) suggests investment value was unchanged. Clearly, it is not the case. The geometric return is lower than the arithmetic return because of volatility. Interestingly, this difference in return is referred to as volatility drag. Note, a buy-and-hold strategy will generate lower returns in volatile markets – higher the volatility, greater the drag. This drag is approximately one-half of the variance of the returns.

Market timing

The other side to buy-and-hold strategy is market timing. Empirical evidence suggests that individuals are typically not good market timers.

Research shows the buy-and-hold returns on investments are significantly higher than the actual returns of a market timer.

This difference is referred to as behaviour gap. It is attributed to error in human judgment – buying when prices rise sharply and selling in panic when prices fall.

How should you balance the volatility drag and the behaviour gap?

Conclusion

You should have pre-determined rules to take profit. For goal-based portfolios, this could be based on the required return you must earn to achieve your goal. Suppose the required return on your equity investments is 12% and the actual return is, say, 14%. You could keep 12% in the portfolio and take out the two percentage points of additional gains.

For trading portfolio, the rule for taking profit can be pre-determined based on price targets or based on continual reading of the charts.

Note, the rule for the trading portfolio moderates volatility drag but forces you to manage future regret (potential behaviour gap) should the prices go up further after you take profit.

(The author offers training programs for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 3.5%
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
Bank of Baroda*	10.15-18.05	10,660-12,710	2,132-2,542	Up to 5% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Axis Bank	9.50 onwards	10,501 onwards	2,100 onwards	Up to 2%
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11.934	2,110-2,387	0.50% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
HSBC Bank	9.95 onwards	10,611 onwards	2,122 onwards	Up to 2%
Federal Bank	11.99 onwards	11,120 onwards	2,224 onwards	Up to 3%
Union Bank of India	8.75 - 12.55	10,319-11,262	2,064-2,252	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.00	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 3.93%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.60-13.85	10,525-11,595	2,105-2,319	0.50%-1%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	1.5%
Bank of Maharashtra	8.75-13.55	10,319-11,518	2,064-2,304	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Central Bank of India	9.85-11.65	10,587-11,034	2,117-2,207	Up to 1%

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Union Bank of India	7.40-9.45	9,995 - 10,489	Up to Rs 1,000
Punjab National Bank	7.55-9.45	10,031 - 10,489	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Canara Bank	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
State Bank of India	8.90 - 9.85	10,355 - 10,587	Rs 750 - Rs 1,500
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	NIL
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
ICICI Bank	8.50 onwards	10,258 onwards	Up to 2%
HDFC Bank	8.20 onwards	10,186 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
Karnataka Bank	8.00-11.50	10,138 - 10,996	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Federal Bank	Up to 11.65	Up to 11,034	Rs. 2,000 - Rs. 4,500
Punjab and Sind Bank**	7.50-14.00	10,019 - 11,634	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Bank	7.50-9.55	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,000
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	Up to Rs. 10,000
Central Bank of India	7.60-9.20	10,043 - 10,428	No processing fees till 31.03.2026

*0.25% interest rate concession for home loan borrowers, existing customers with 6 months of relationship with the bank

**Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam

Rates and charges as on February 11

Source: Paisabazaar.com

Rubio visits eastern Europe to bolster ties with Hungary, Slovakia



Syria's Defence Ministry says it has taken over another base from U.S.



Europeans push back at U.S. over its 'civilisational erasure' claim



'Iran open to compromises to reach nuclear deal with U.S.'



Opposition set to test BNP's dominance

Israeli air strikes kill 12 in Gaza; Hamas violated truce, says Israel

Russia's Taman port damaged in strikes

Board of Peace states have pledged \$5 bn for Gaza humanitarian relief, announces Trump



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The Under-19 World Cup can announce a talent. It cannot secure a career. The real test begins after the spotlight fades, when workload and expectation shape who survives senior cricket.

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SUCCESS MANTRA

‘Sometimes, you just have to believe and focus on strengths’



AFP

The pitch was not that easy to bat on. Sometimes, you just have to believe and focus on your strengths. I was just watching the ball, sticking to my strengths and making them (Pakistan) run as much as possible. I did work a lot on my off-side game, so then I can have them bowl where I want them to — Ishan Kishan.

TRUSTED FORMULA

Pakistan equals record for most overs of spin in a T20 WC innings



PTI

Pakistan bowled 18 overs of spin in the T20 World Cup match against India in Colombo on Sunday. It was also the most overs of slow bowling ever in a World Cup innings, equalling its own record against Australia at the same venue in the 2012 edition. Pakistan used as many as six tweakers after opting to field.

FAMILY MATTERS

Ferguson returns home for the birth of his first child



PTI

New Zealand pacer Lockie Ferguson has returned home to be with his wife for the birth of their first child and miss the team's final Group D match against Canada in the T20 World Cup. Head coach Rob Walter said the plan is for Ferguson to rejoin the squad for the Super Eight should it reach that stage.

MOMENTOUS WIN

‘What the Mosca brothers did for us at Wankhede was truly special’



K.R. DEEPAK

What the Mosca brothers — Justin and Anthony — did for us at the Wankhede [against Nepal], that was a truly special partnership that they put on. And we've touched on it, how well the team played as a whole. We were brilliant in the field. And with the ball, we executed our plans exceptionally well — Italy captain Wayne Madsen.

Kishan and bowlers help India annihilate Pakistan

The opener's blinder powers the defending champion to 175 for seven on a sluggish surface; Hardik, Bumrah, Axar and Varun scalp two each as the Men in Blue seal a spot in Super Eight

T20 WORLD CUP

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
COLOMBO

The Indian juggernaut rolled on even as the rains that were forecast stayed away from the R. Premadasa Stadium here on an electric Sunday. The defending champion rode on Ishan Kishan's muscular 77 and its potent attack to defeat Pakistan by 61 runs in the ICC T20 World Cup Group A match. The win also helped India qualify for the Super Eight stage.

After posting 175 for seven, Suryakumar Yadav's men bowled out Pakistan for 114 in 18 overs. The pursuit was in a shambles when Sahibzada Farhan, Saim Ayub and captain Salman Agha were back in the hut with a mere 13 on the board. Hardik Pandya, with a wicket and a catch, and Jasprit Bumrah, two wickets in his kitty, were the initial speed-breakers for the rivals.

Pakistan's woes extended as Babar Azam found Axar Patel sliding one into his stumps. Meanwhile, Usman Khan waged a lone battle, striking cleanly down the ground. But once he succumbed to Axar, with Kishan whipping the bails off, Pakistan was down for the count.

Earlier, Agha won the toss, elected to field, and found the mark through his spinning arm. Abhishek Sharma, back in the Indian playing XI, miscued a pull and India was one for



Demolition job: Kishan played the Pakistan attack before effecting a stumping to cut short Usman's promising innings. Skipper Suryakumar and Tilak celebrate the fall of Shadab. Tariq is cleaned up by Hardik to signal the end of the contest. PTI, AP & REUTERS

one after the first over.

But there were no premature nerves as Kishan (77, 40b, 10x4, 3x6) smote pacer Shaheen Afridi's first ball for six. The opener played his shots with conviction, and even when a few edges raced past the ropes, he refused to turn conservative. The south-paw remained busy, pull-

ing, gliding, hoisting and driving past fifty as no part of the ground was beyond his reach.

A spin-heavy Pakistan attack struggled to stifle Kishan while his partner Tilak Varma stayed on 10 for a while. Having reverse-hit Saim, Kishan tried to force one on the off-side and got castled but by then



he had set a strong base for India. A bustling Suryakumar hit a four off Usman Tariq, Tilak exhaled with a six off Mohammad Nawaz and India cruised.

A brief stutter occurred when Tilak and Hardik fell off successive deliveries against Saim. Shivam Dube averted the hat-trick and along with his skipper,

eased into a partnership based on singles and elevated by the odd four and six.

Even after Suryakumar fell to Tariq, Dube remained busy and despite India losing two more batters in the death, there was enough and more to stay ahead of Pakistan for the rest of the night.

SCOREBOARD

INDIA
Ishan Kishan b Saim 77 (40b, 10x4, 3x6), Abhishek Sharma c Afridi b Agha 0 (4b), Tilak Varma lbw b Saim 25 (24b, 2x4, 1x6), Suryakumar Yadav c Saim b Tariq 32 (29b, 3x4), Hardik Pandya c Babar b Saim 0 (1b), Shivam Dube run out 27 (17b, 3x4, 1x6), Rinku Singh (not out) 11 (4b, 1x4, 1x6), Axar Patel c Saim b Afridi 0 (1b); Extras (lb-2, w-1): 3; Total (for seven wkts. in 20 overs): 175.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-1 (Abhishek, 0.6 overs), 2-88 (Kishan, 8.4), 3-126 (Tilak, 14.2), 4-126 (Hardik, 14.3), 5-159 (Suryakumar, 18.5), 6-175 (Dube, 19.5), 7-175 (Axar, 19.6).

PAKISTAN BOWLING
Agha 2-0-10-1, Afridi 2-0-31-1, Saim 4-0-25-3, Abrar 3-0-38-0, Shadab 1-0-17-0, Nawaz 4-0-28-0, Tariq 4-0-24-1.

PAKISTAN
Sahibzada Farhan c Rinku b Hardik 0 (4b), Saim Ayub lbw b Bumrah 6 (2b, 1x6), Salman Agha c Hardik b Bumrah 4 (4b, 1x4), Babar Azam b Axar 5 (7b), Usman Khan st. Kishan b Axar 44 (34b, 6x4, 1x6), Shadab Khan c Dube b Tilak 14 (15b, 1x4), Mohammad Nawaz c Dube b Kuldeep 4 (5b, 1x4), Faheem Ashraf c Rinku b Varun 10 (14b, 1x4), Shaheen Afridi (not out) 23 (19b, 2x4, 1x6), Abrar Ahmed lbw b Varun 0 (1b), Usman Tariq b Hardik 0 (3b); Extras (lb-1, w-3): 4; Total (in 18 overs): 114.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-0 (Farhan, 0.4), 2-6 (Saim, 1.2), 3-13 (Agha, 1.6), 4-34 (Babar, 4.5), 5-73 (Usman, 10.4), 6-78 (Nawaz, 11.4), 7-78 (Shadab, 12.1), 8-97 (Ashraf, 15.3), 9-97 (Abrar, 15.4).

INDIA BOWLING
Hardik 3-1-16-2, Bumrah 2-0-17-2, Axar 4-0-29-2, Varun 3-0-17-2, Kuldeep 3-0-14-1, Tilak 2-0-11-1, Rinku 1-0-9-0.
Toss: Pakistan; **PoM:** Kishan. India won by 61 runs.

India's next match: Feb. 18 vs. Netherlands, Ahmedabad, 7 p.m.

Kishan took the game away from us: Hesson

Anish Pathiyil
COLOMBO

Pakistan head coach Mike Hesson said it was Ishan Kishan's counter-attacking knock, rather than a top-order collapse, that proved to be the difference between the two sides in its 61-run submission to India here.

Hesson said that his bowlers felt the pressure against the opener and ended up conceding 25 runs more than the par-score for the conditions. "The ball was spinning quite a lot initially. The way Kishan played took the game away from us. He's fearless and can score on both sides of the ground, which makes it a challenge for spinners in the Power-Play. He forced them away from the basics," the Kiwi said.

"From a batting point of view, we did not give ourselves a chance to get ad-

justed to the conditions. They bowled nicely up front with the seam, and we took a few poor options," he said.

Hesson rebuked the idea that the pressure of the contest is what causes his team to underperform. "I know it's a huge event — Pakistan against India. But we have played some good cricket, winning five games on the bounce. We are really disappointed we didn't play as well as we could," he said.

India vice-captain Axar Patel also lavished praise on Kishan, calling it one of his best knocks in international cricket.

"The way he batted, it wasn't easy because the ball was spinning. He has carried forward his form from domestic cricket, and when the confidence is high, you don't think much about yourself or the wicket," the spin-bowling all-rounder said.



Early burst: Bumrah's twin strikes rocked Pakistan. ANI



Status quo: Suryakumar continued the policy of not shaking hands with the Pakistan skipper at the toss. AFP

No handshake between Suryakumar and Agha

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
COLOMBO

Sport is about competing hard while retaining its essential spirit centred around grace. Shaking hands with an opponent is a basic component of any sporting endeavour. Even if India against Pakistan on the cricketing turf, is seen as war minus the shooting, a certain etiquette was in vogue until the recent years.

However, that warm trait has been discarded as Indian captain Suryakumar Yadav avoided shaking hands with his Pakistani counterpart Salman Agha

at the toss, ahead of the ICC T20 World Cup Group A match here at the R. Premadasa Stadium on Sunday. This aversion to a sporting tradition was first revealed last year when India competed against Pakistan in the Asia Cup in the United Arab Emirates.

Obviously there have been instructions from the highest levels of administration and the Men in Blue are perhaps following that. It is ironical that when Wasim Akram and Harbhajan Singh can hug and shake hands as commentators, their successors seem to be caught in a political slug-fest.

West Indies maintains perfect record, advances in style

Shayan Acharya
MUMBAI

It was another day of heart-break for the thousands of Nepalese fans, who turned up at the Wankhede Stadium on Sunday, as the West Indies stormed into the Super Eight of the T20 World Cup with a nine-wicket win.

Jason Holder (for for 27) broke the back of the middle-order and was instrumental in restricting Nepal to 133 for eight.

Later, an unbroken 91-run partnership between captain Shai Hope (61 n.o., 44b, 5x4, 3x6) and Shimron Hetmyer (46 n.o., 32b, 4x4, 2x6) guided the West Indies home with 28 balls to spare. While Nepal crashed out following its third consecutive defeat, the Caribbean side maintained its unbeaten record in Group C with a third straight victory.

After being sent in to bat, Nepal struggled as it lost three wickets early on and could score just 22 runs in the PowerPlay — the lowest of the tournament so far.



Incisive spell: Holder broke the back of the Nepalese middle-order. EMMANUEL YOGINI

At the end of the 11th over as Nepal was reeling at 46 for five, with Holder and Matthew Forde bowling a tight line and length and mixing it up with some

short-pitched deliveries.

Until then, Dipendra Singh Airee fought a lone battle. However, things changed at the fag end as Dipendra forged a 54-run

While Nepal crashed out following its third consecutive defeat, the Caribbean side notched up its third straight victory

partnership for the seventh wicket with the team's senior-most player Sompal Kami.

While Dipendra cleared the ropes twice in the penultimate over and notched up his fifty, Sompal brought the crowd to its feet with three consecutive boundaries off Holder.

But those efforts went futile as the West Indies chased down the total without breaking a sweat.

As the surface eased out, openers Hope and Brandon King added 43 runs, despite the latter struggling to time the ball.

However, once Hetmyer and Hope took charge, it was West Indies all the way.

The scores: Nepal 133/8 in 20 overs (Dipendra Singh Airee 58, Holder 4/27) lost to West Indies 134/1 in 15.2 overs (Shai Hope 61 n.o., Shimron Hetmyer 46 n.o.); **Toss:** West Indies; **PoM:** Holder.

Points table					
GROUP A					
	M	W	L	NRR	PTS
India (Q)	3	3	0	3.050	6
USA	4	2	2	0.788	4
Pakistan	3	2	1	-0.403	4
Netherlands	3	1	2	-1.352	2
Namibia	3	0	3	-2.443	0
GROUP B					
	M	W	L	NRR	PTS
Sri Lanka	2	2	0	3.125	4
Zimbabwe	2	2	0	1.984	4
Australia	2	1	1	1.100	2
Ireland	3	1	2	0.150	2
Oman	3	0	3	-4.546	0
GROUP C					
	M	W	L	NRR	PTS
West Indies (Q)	3	3	0	1.820	6
England	3	2	1	-0.143	4
Scotland	3	1	2	0.359	2
Italy	2	1	1	-0.352	2
Nepal	3	0	3	-1.942	0
GROUP D					
	M	W	L	NRR	PTS
South Africa	3	3	0	1.477	6
New Zealand	3	2	1	0.701	4
UAE	2	1	1	-1.030	2
Afghanistan	2	0	2	-0.555	0
Canada	2	0	2	-1.526	0

Q: QUALIFIED

A CH-CE

Rahul and Padikkal feast on Uttarakhand bowlers

The Karnataka batters, scoring a century each, have a field day with a 278-run alliance for the second wicket; the first-time semifinalist would have been left ruing the decision to bowl first



Dazzling duo: Rahul and Padikkal made full use of the batting-friendly conditions on the opening day. R.V. MOORTHY

RANJI TROPHY

N. Sudarshan
LUCKNOW

Batting first is increasingly seen as the first step into a dystopian world. So comfortable are teams chasing a known target - especially in limited-overs cricket - that sides wield the willow first only to “challenge” themselves.

One wonders if Uttarakhand was thinking on these lines when it chose to field on the first morning of the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy semifinal against Karnataka at the Ekana Cricket Stadium on Sunday. It was, admittedly, a red-ball game, but it is a format

where the first-innings lead matters.

But by stumps, Kunal Chandela & Co. would have been left ruing that decision as Karnataka rode on K.L. Rahul’s 25th First Class ton (141, 21lb, 11x4, 5x6) and skipper Devdutt Padikkal’s ninth (148 batting, 236b, 16x4, 2x6) to rack up 355 for two.

First-time semifinalist Uttarakhand will now be hoping that when it eventually bats, the pitch stays as true as it did on day one.

There was the odd ball that bounced disconcertingly and there were a few that seamed, but none too dangerous.

And Rahul and Padikkal feasted, putting on a grand 278-run partnership after Mayank Agarwal was

caught early in the slips. Rahul was reprieved on 47 when wicketkeeper Sourabh Rawat missed a stumping off an arm ball from Mayank Mishra (18-1-88-0), and survived a half-chance on 136 when the cherry fell short of the slip fielder. But for those moments, and until a leading edge led to his downfall, his stay was chanceless.

The 33-year-old drove beautifully, pulled efficiently and danced down the track in a sure-footed manner.

The half-century came in 86 balls when he cut pacer Aditya Rawat to the point boundary. The hundred was raised in 153 deliveries, his second consecutive ton after the match-winning 130 against

Mumbai in the quarterfinal. Padikkal was no less enthralling. He started off with two fine cuts off Aditya before peppering every other part of the ground.

The half-ton came off just 65 balls and the century milestone was passed with a one-handed six - two definitive signs of the day’s ease.

The scores: Karnataka — 1st innings: K.L. Rahul c & b Aditya 141, Mayank Agarwal c Prashant b Aditya 5, Devdutt Padikkal (batting) 148, Karun Nair (batting) 37; Extras (b-9, lb-5, nb-4, w-6): 24; Total (for two wkts. in 90 overs): 355.

Fall of wickets: 1-18, 2-296.

Uttarakhand bowling: Abhay 17-2-55-0, Janmejay 18-3-44-0, Aditya 14-2-73-2, Mayank 18-1-88-0, J. Suchith 10-0-43-0, Avneesh 13-0-38-0.

Toss: Uttarakhand.

In-form Gharami leads Bengal’s charge against J & K

Y.B. Sarangi
KALYANI

Oozing confidence following his marathon knock in the quarterfinals, Sudip Gharami scored his second consecutive century to take Bengal to 249 for five on the opening day of its Ranji Trophy semifinal match against Jammu & Kashmir at the Bengal Cricket Academy ground here on Sunday.

Thanks to Gharami’s unbeaten 136 (227b, 19x4, 1x6), Bengal, asked to bat, registered a decent total. On a conducive track, J & K pacers exploited the pleasant morning conditions to get some movement and left-armed Sunil Kumar removed Sudip Chatterjee in the second over.

Riding his luck, Gharami batted positively and used DRS to get two decisions overturned. He also saw Yudhvir Singh grass a difficult caught and bowled chance early. After 18 dot balls, Gharami spectacularly opened his account by hoisting left-arm seamer Sunil Kumar over long-off. He formed a vital 85-run partnership with skipper Abhimanyu Easwaran (49, 96b, 6x4, 1x6), who drove and cut nicely, as they blunted the hard-working rival pace attack.

The script changed swiftly after lunch as J & K pace spearhead Auqib Nabi, displaying exceptional application with discipline and consistency, scalped Abhimanyu and Suraj Jaiswal. Abhimanyu could not protect his off-stump, while Jaiswal edged one to the ‘keeper.



Lynchpin: Gharami’s assured knock came at the right time for Bengal. RITU RAJ KONWAR

An unperturbed Gharami, who cut deftly, drove authoritatively and swept assuredly, forged another 66-run stand with a sedate Anustup Majumdar as Bengal consolidated its position.

Gharami reached his eighth hundred in the first over after tea and kissed his locket like Virat Kohli. He formed a critical 94-run stand with Shahbaz Ahmed, who played a supporting role after getting dropped on one off Nabi. They played deliveries on merit as an overenthusiastic J & K spent its reviews by the 56th over.

Flourishing well, Gharami made a statement by

unleashing two glorious straight drives for four off Yudhvir before Sunil dismissed Shahbaz (42, 91b, 4x4) to enliven J & K before stumps.

The scores: Bengal — 1st innings: Abhimanyu Easwaran b Nabi 49, Sudip Chatterjee c Pundir b Sunil 0, Sudip Gharami (batting) 136, Suraj Jaiswal c Wadhawan b Nabi 0, Anustup Majumdar lbw b Abid 14, Shahbaz Ahmed lbw b Sunil 42; Extras (lb-2, nb-5, w-1): 8; Total (for five wkts. in 79.5 overs): 249.

Fall of wickets: 1-4, 2-89, 3-89, 4-155, 5-249.

Jammu & Kashmir bowling: Nabi 18-3-48-2, Sunil 16.5-7-31-2, Yudhvir 13-4-47-0, Abid 18-3-80-1, Vanshaj 11-1-34-0, Samad 3-0-7-0.

Toss: Jammu & Kashmir.



Thompson-Herah. AP

Jamaica’s Thompson-Herah runs first race since 2024

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

Jamaican sprinter Elaine Thompson-Herah, a five-time Olympic champion, competed in her first race since June 2024 in Saturday’s Camperdown Classic at Kingston, Jamaica.

Thompson-Herah, who won back-to-back Olympic titles at 100 and 200 metres in 2016 at Rio and five years later in Tokyo, was third at 60 meters in 7.24 seconds (-1.7 m/s wind). It was an encouraging return for Thompson-Herah, who has been hampered by injuries for several years, including an Achilles injury in 2024.

Thompson-Herah has not competed in an individual international championship since the 2022 World Championships in Eugene, Oregon, where she took bronze in the 100m and silver in the 4x100m relay. She settled for the relay at the 2023 World Championships in Budapest and had only competed in two races in 2024.

EDUCATIONPLUS

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Sanil Raj Johnson

As higher education in India becomes more flexible and multidisciplinary, the continued requirement of the Equivalency Certificate — that students need to submit when applying at different universities — remains a barrier to student mobility.

What initially appears to be a simple academic verification has, over time, transformed into a complex bureaucratic process.

At its core, the system is meant to ensure that a student’s prior degree meets the receiving university’s academic standards. However, without a national policy and a clear mechanism, universities have started to see equivalency as a gatekeeping tool rather than a standardisation process. This has led to confusion, inconsistency, and, more worryingly, systemic exclusion.

Long process

To begin with, securing equivalency requires students to gather an exhaustive set of documents: detailed syllabi for every semester, course scheme and regulations, the programme structure and duration, mode of examination and even evidence such as the institution’s NAAC grade and NIRF ranking.

The university’s Registrar must authenticate these, a process that can take weeks. After these documents are submitted,



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

The equivalency trap

Equivalency has become a gatekeeping tool rather than a standardisation process leading to confusion, inconsistency, and systemic exclusion

their application moves through different layers of scrutiny, typically beginning with the relevant Board of Studies and ending with the Academic Council.

This long process does not guarantee approval. Many universities insist on an unwritten rule that the syllabus submitted must match at least 60% of their own. This has no basis in the University Grants Commission’s regulations, yet is widely and rigidly enforced.

It is also deeply flawed because no two universities design their programmes

with uniformity in mind. Autonomous colleges, state universities, and institutions across different States develop their syllabi independently based on regional needs, faculty expertise, and institutional priorities. Expecting a significant percentage of similarity between such diverse curricular frameworks is unrealistic.

Double and triple majors

The situation becomes even more complicated when students graduate from institutions offering double-major or triple-major

degrees. These programmes have expanded steadily in India over the last decade, long before the introduction of the Four-Year Undergraduate Programme. Their purpose is to broaden learning and enable students to pursue postgraduate studies in any one of their major subjects.

But when students apply for higher studies elsewhere, they are forced to prove equivalency in one of the subjects they studied, even when the postgraduate programme does not require subject-specific eligibility.

A student with a triple-

major degree in Economics, Political Science and Journalism may be denied admission to a Master of Social Work programme simply because none of the subjects matches the 60% similarity criterion, even though MSW programmes typically accept graduates from any discipline.

A recent case illustrates the system’s irrationality. A student who completed a triple-major degree in Psychology, Zoology, and Botany from a university in Karnataka sought admission to an M.A. English programme at a university in Kerala.

According to the regulations, a graduate with the required marks and performance in the entrance examination was eligible, regardless of the subjects studied at the undergraduate level. The student met these requirements and qualified through the entrance test.

However, because he had studied three majors, the institute asked him to secure equivalency in at least one. After reviewing his syllabi, he found that Botany had the closest overlap and applied for equivalency in that subject. Unfortunately, the Board decided that what he had studied in Karnataka did not align sufficiently with what was taught in Kerala and rejected the request. As a result, he was denied admission, despite Botany having no relevance to the course.

Thus, equivalency became a procedural hurdle that blocked a student who had already demonstrated his merit.

Need for one policy

Cases such as these are not anomalies. With more than four crore students enrolled in India’s higher education institutions and increasing numbers choosing to pursue degrees outside their home States, the demand for equivalency certificates is rising sharply.

India needs a transparent national policy on equivalency to support student mobility and prevent universities from enforcing arbitrary criteria. This must abandon outdated subject-wise equivalency requirements for postgraduate programmes that already accept graduates from any discipline.

It should also recognise

multidisciplinary degrees without forcing students to approach unrelated Boards of Studies and shift the focus from syllabus matching to outcome-based measures that reflect modern academic standards.

The country is at a pivotal moment in its educational reform.

While the National Education Policy promotes flexibility, interdisciplinarity, and student-centred learning, the current equivalency system remains one of the most regressive elements of university administration.

Views expressed are personal.

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I'm trying to create a solid team, a good environment and a squad that is consistent

India's national table tennis coach aspires to inculcate the winning mentality in the group and is hopeful of delivering the results; he believes the youngsters coming through can push the seniors, is confident of another successful tenure



BISWARANJAN ROUT

INTERVIEW

Massimo Costantini

K. Keerthivasan
CHENNAI

India's national table tennis head coach Massimo Costantini loves India so much that he joked the other day, "I would love to be the head coach of the national team till the time India host the Olympics!"

Truth be told, Costantini's earlier two spells were successful. Now, in his third tenure, the 67-year-old is focused on putting a clear structure in place, nurturing a strong team environment and securing a permanent training base for the Indian squad. With his contract due for renewal in May, the Italian hopes to continue in the role at least until the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

Costantini spoke to *The Hindu* on the sidelines of the WTT Star Contender here. Excerpts:

What do you think of the field at the WTT Star Contender in Chennai and how well can Indians perform here?

Overall, it will be challenging for both men and women. For men, we have good chances to do well. Manav Thakkar has been doing well on the International circuit. So is Manush Shah who has been doing quite well in men's singles, doubles and mixed doubles on the WTT tour. I think the tournament will be more challenging for our women. Because in women, we have Japanese and Koreans who are very strong. But we will try our best as always.

Manav is playing very well, reaching a career-best world ranking of 33. How do you see his game progressing?

I see that finally after so many discussions, after so many analyses of his game. I think now he has found his game. Earlier, he was doing everything, not sharpening the real skills, which is speed. He has improved

that. No one can stand his speed. These are skills that if you apply on the table, they are very effective. Manav needs to be more mature to know how to manage those skills. And this is a challenge for every player. Every player is skilled, but don't know how to use them. I'm expecting even better results from Manav.

The Indian players have had some good results with Manav doing well and Manush Shah and Diya Chitale winning a WTT Contender title in Muscat last month, but we have not been able to perform consistently at the top level. Is that a concern?

Of course, winning a tournament is always good. Nothing can be taken for granted. Today you can reach the final, but the next day you can lose in the first round. One of the most difficult aspects of this entire circus is to be consistent. We can have one good performance and then maybe one, two, three, not that good performance. We have to work to find a way that we can consistently be there.

Once we reach that kind of level, we can feel that mentality, the winning mentality. If you ask the same question to the Japanese, they will tell you, yes, 'I'm expecting at least a semifinal'. Because they are used to it. For the last two years, Japanese have reached at least semifinals on the pro tour

When I joined in 2024, I said that India can be a powerhouse like other countries. But we need a lot more things to be put in place

regularly. For us, it's still ups and downs. Yes, we are not consistent enough.

In the Asian championships held in October 2025 in Bhubaneswar, Indian men finished sixth and women eighth whereas in the previous edition in Astana, Indian men and women had bagged a bronze medal each, and in the ITTF-Asian Cup held this month, only Akash Pal reached the round of 16 while the rest of them were eliminated early in the group stages. Was it disappointing?

In the Asian team championships, we didn't have our full team {senior players, Harmeet Desai and G. Sathiyam did not compete in men's while Sreeja Akula pulled out due to shoulder injury in women's}. While every other team had their best

team, we didn't. But that is no excuse. At the Asian Cup in Haikou (China), Akash did well, I thought, losing to current World No.2 Shin Lidong of China in the round of 16. In the last one year, our performance was not bad. I'm quite okay especially with men. They were a little bit behind when compared to the women. Now, they are catching up because we are very close to having two players in world's top 50 [Manav and Sathiyam at 51]. It's really encouraging. Of course, we have had some big challenges with the injury to Sreeja Akula.

You have always spoken about team spirit and good environment among the players. How close are you to achieving it?

So, the work that I'm trying to create a solid team and also a team that is consistent, to train the team and create a nice environment for the players. It has been slow to come, but it is coming. We are working with Sports Authority of India to create a sort of a permanent training camp for the Indian players. I'm confident that it will happen soon.

This year is important as we have the World team championships from April 30 to May 10 and the Asian Games in September-October in Japan. Indian (men and women) team rankings aren't great.

The Indian men are 12th in the world while the women are in 11th place. Which means we are ranked fifth in Asia in men and sixth in women. As far as selection of the team for the World teams is concerned, my advice is to wait for the National championships [to be held in Indore from March 14] to end and select the team. We have time until April 8 for the team replacement. To me, it makes sense to wait for the Nationals and see who is performing. We have time for Asian Games. We have a good chance in men's doubles (Manush Shah and Manav

Thakkar) and mixed doubles (Manush and Diya Chitale). We will have a clear picture in July.

There are a lot of youngsters who have come up. Among the lot, who you think can shine for India at the highest level?

The 19-year-old Ankur (Bhattacharjee) is capable of great performance. In the recently concluded Asian Cup, he defeated World No.27 Chen Yuanyu of China. I believe he needs to be, for his age, more mature. He should be able to manage his skills. He has unlimited skills.

Then, there is Abhinandh, Priyanuj Bhattacharyya (17), Punit Biswas (17), Kushal Chopra (18). These are the players [barring Kushal] who won India the silver in the World youth (u-19) championships in Romania last year. In girls, we have Divyanshi Bhowmick (15), Syndrela Das (16) and Ankolika Chakraborty (14). I think this group is going to push the seniors a lot.

This is your third stint as the National head coach that began at the 2024 Paris Olympics. How do you see your future with the Indian team?

I believe that we have started a good process. Normally, we work in a four-year cycle. So, starting in 2024, it would make sense to complete the cycle in 2028. And then, in between, build a good quality of coaches. And to have a better mentality. And overall, a better environment, infrastructure, and so on. You don't work only for results. You work to leave something behind. It happened in 2018 where we won two medals in Asian Games and a total of eight medals in Commonwealth Games. I think my legacy was there in 2018. And I want to leave a better legacy than 2018. That's my dream. When I joined in 2024, I said that India can be a powerhouse like other countries. But we need a lot more things to be put in place. Luckily, we have very good support from the Table Tennis Federation of India, Union Government, Sports Authority of India and TOPS. My contract ends in May. I would like to continue until 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.



K. MURALI KUMAR

Cows can use tools, and one Austrian cow has now shown it clearly

A cow named Veronika has been documented using a brush as a tool, choosing different ends and techniques for different body parts. The finding challenges long-held assumptions about cattle cognition and suggests our environments and biases, rather than animals, set the limits of what we notice

Sayantana Datta

In 1960, when she was studying chimpanzees in Tanzania, the primatologist Jane Goodall observed one chimp strip a stick of its leaves and use it to extract termites from a mound. She telegraphed her observation to her supervisor, the paleoanthropologist Louis Leakey. “Now we must redefine ‘tool,’ redefine ‘man’ or accept chimpanzees as human,” Leakey replied. More than six decades later, another such moment has arrived – this time with an unlikely protagonist: Veronika, a cow in Austria.

A cow uses a tool
University of Veterinary Medicine, Austria, cognitive biologist and associate professor Alice Auersperg first learnt of Veronika in a video she received. It purported to show “a cow using a stick-like object to scratch her body in a way that did not appear accidental,” she recalled. She forwarded the clip to her colleague Antonio J. Osuna Mascaró. Both researchers study how animals perceive, learn, remember, solve problems, and make decisions. They recognised that Veronika’s actions were “not a case of simple rubbing against objects,” Dr. Osuna-Mascaró said. Instead, the cow appeared to be “actively manipulating an object, orienting it, and using it to reach specific body parts.” In other words, Veronika was demonstrating “genuine tool use”, something that had not been previously reported in cattle. Still, the team was cautious. “Most claims of animal tool use do not survive careful scrutiny,” Dr. Osuna-Mascaró explained. This is because scientists consider an animal’s interaction with objects to be tool use only when it uses its body to manipulate the object and achieve a goal. This is why dogs scratching against trees doesn’t count whereas chimpanzees fashioning spears out of sticks to hunt galagos does. To check whether Veronika’s behaviour met this definition, the team travelled to Nötsch im Gailtal, the Austrian town where Veronika lived. If they could confirm their suspicions, Veronika’s tool use would prove “cattle possess more behavioural flexibility than they are usually credited with,” Dr. Auersperg said.

Scratch the itch
In Nötsch, the researchers designed an experiment to test Veronika’s abilities. They chose a wooden scrubbing brush with bristles at the end of a smooth, long handle and expected Veronika to (a) use the brush to scratch parts of her body that were otherwise hard to reach, and (b) show a preference for the bristled end.

In more than 70 instances, the team



Unlike Veronika, who has access to open meadows and human interaction, most cattle spend their lives in barren environments. This means if farm animals were provided with richer environments, they could show more such behaviours. VOL. 36, ISSUE 2, PR44-R45 JANUARY 19, 2026

presented the brush to Veronika in different orientations – all to ensure her preference for one end couldn’t be explained by how the brush was positioned. In almost every instance, Veronika lifted the brush with her tongue, held it between her teeth, and scratched the rear half of her body. And she used the bristled end more often. Veronika’s behaviour was thus evidence of “goal-directed, context-sensitive tooling,” the team reported in a January 2026 *Current Biology* paper.

A surprise
There were, however, a small number of trials when Veronika used the handle. The team assumed these to be errors at first until they realised Veronika was “targeting different body areas with each end of the tool,” Dr. Osuna-Mascaró told this reporter. Veronika was using the abrasive bristles to scratch the thick skin of her upper body. But when scratching the delicate skin of her lower body, such as her udders, she used the smooth handle-end. The team also saw Veronika use different techniques with the two ends. When using the bristled end, she raised the brush, rested it at a spot on the skin, then pulled it forward in what the researchers dubbed a “scrubbing motion”. Her movements with the handle-end were however more precise and gentle “forward pushes”. Veronika was not only using a tool but

In more than 70 instances, the team presented the brush to Veronika in different orientations: in almost every instance, Veronika lifted the brush with her tongue, held it between her teeth, and scratched the rear half of her body

using it in different ways had the team surprised. “It is astonishing to find that a cow has the capability to do something like this,” Dr. Osuna-Mascaró said.

Just noticing
Veronika’s abilities are rivalled so far only by one other animal species: chimpanzees. In the 2000s, researchers described chimpanzees in Congo using one end of a stick to pierce termite mounds and using the other, frayed end to scoop the insects out. Ideally, Veronika’s abilities shouldn’t surprise us: “Given that there are numerous instances where cows have been recorded to make use of their tongues ... to open locks... it is not very surprising,” University of Hyderabad associate professor of neural and cognitive sciences Joby Joseph said. At the same time, he agreed that “very few study and report these behaviours [in cattle]”. Primatologist Sindhu Radhakrishna, a professor at the National Institute of Advanced Studies, Bengaluru, agreed.

She added that Veronika’s tool-use challenges biologists to rethink why “they expect to see ‘higher’ cognition in some species but don’t expect to see it in others.” According to Dr. Osuna-Mascaró, cattle are seen as less intelligent than they actually are for two reasons: “a lack of opportunity and observation,” and due to “anthropocentric and utilitarian assumptions about animal minds”. Anthropocentrism is the belief that human beings are superior to all other life.

Animal farm
Unlike Veronika, who has access to open meadows and human interaction, most cattle spend their lives in “barren environments with limited opportunities to manipulate objects,” Dr. Osuna-Mascaró explained. This means if farm animals were provided with richer environments, they could show more such behaviours. That, Dr. Osuna-Mascaró expressed hope, would ultimately force us to “reconsider how we treat them”. In the end, the discovery perhaps speaks more about humans than cattle. Despite co-existing for about 10,000 years, it is only now that scientists are taking cows’ mental abilities seriously. The real question then is “not whether cows can use tools, but why it took us so long to notice,” Dr. Osuna-Mascaró said. (Sayantan Datta is a faculty member at Krea University and an independent science journalist. dattasayantana95@gmail.com)

THE GIST

Scientists consider an animal’s interaction with objects to be tool use only when it uses its body to manipulate the object and achieve a goal

Veronika used “a stick-like object to scratch her body in a way that did not appear accidental”. Tool use such as this has not been reported in cattle earlier

Veronika’s behaviour was evidence of “goal-directed, context-sensitive tooling”

BIG SHOT



Smoke and lava erupting and flowing from the Piton de la Fournaise volcano, in the southeast of the French overseas island of La Reunion on February 13. The Piton de la Fournaise volcano on Reunion Island erupted for the second time this year on February 13 and is one of the most active volcanoes in the world. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

LHS 1903: a strange system

Reuters

Astronomers have observed a planetary system that challenges current planet formation theories, with a rocky planet that formed beyond the orbits of its gaseous neighbors, possibly after much of the planet-forming material had been used up. The system, observed using the European Space Agency’s Cheops space telescope, consists of four planets, two rocky and two gaseous, orbiting a relatively small and dim star called a red dwarf about 117 light-years from the earth. The star, named LHS 1903, is about 50% as massive and 5% as luminous as our sun. The innermost planet is rocky, the next two are gaseous and the fourth, which current planetary formation theory suggests should be gaseous, is rocky. The two rocky planets are superearths, meaning rocky like the earth but two to ten times more massive. The two gas planets are categorised as mini-Neptunes: gaseous and smaller than Neptune but larger than the earth. The researchers suspect that rather than forming all at once in a large disk of gas and dust swirling around their host star, the system’s planets formed



An artist’s impression of the LHS 1903 planetary system. REUTERS

in series, with gas that otherwise would have made up the atmosphere of the fourth planet being used up by its sibling planets before it coalesced. Another possibility is that the planet was born with a gaseous atmosphere that later was lost in a calamity, leaving behind just the rocky planetary core. This fourth planet also is interesting because its surface temperature is 60° C, which means it could be habitable.

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

The number of people killed in Gaza in Israeli strikes on Sunday

12 Gaza's civil defence agency reported that Israeli strikes killed at least 12 people on Sunday, while a military official said the attacks were in response to ceasefire violations. Despite a U.S.-brokered truce that entered its second phase last month, violence has continued. AFP

Amount sanctioned by Himachal govt. for healthcare facilities

1,617 In ₹ crore. Aiming to provide affordable, high-quality healthcare services across the State, the Himachal Pradesh government has approved ₹1,617 crore in the first phase of a ₹3,000-crore comprehensive healthcare modernisation plan. PTI

Worth of Central govt. projects approved in last one year in Assam

55,000 In ₹ crore. Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said that central projects worth around ₹55,000 crore have been sanctioned for the State in the last one year. Mr. Sarma spoke about a range of projects in Assam. PTI

Persons killed over 3 days during attack on Sudan's el-Fasher

6,000 More than 6,000 people were killed over three days when a Sudanese paramilitary group unleashed “a wave of intense violence ... shocking in its scale and brutality” in Sudan's Darfur region in October, the UN said in a recent report. PTI

Indonesian troops to be potentially deployed to Gaza

8,000 Indonesia's military said that up to 8,000 troops are expected to be ready by the end of June for a potential deployment to Gaza as part of a humanitarian and peace mission. AP

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Ambiguities in the U.S.-India trade deal

The interim agreement raises several uncomfortable questions on a wide spectrum of issues, from its likely impact on several key stakeholders in India, particularly farmers, to the ability of the Indian government to take sovereign decisions in critical areas

WORLD INSIGHT

Biswajit Dhar

Almost a year after India agreed to launch negotiations for a bilateral trade agreement with the U.S., the two countries took the first step by agreeing on an interim agreement. This agreement ends a period of fractured ties between the two strategic partners that began in August 2025 when U.S. President Donald Trump imposed 25% tariffs on imports from India, and additional tariffs of 25% as penalty for importing Russian crude oil.

As per the interim agreement, the U.S. will reduce tariffs on India's imports from 50% to 18% while India makes three significant concessions. First, India will eliminate or reduce tariffs and non-tariff barriers on its imports of all industrial goods and a wide range of food and agricultural products from the U.S. Secondly, India, as per Mr. Trump's Executive Order issued alongside the Joint Statement, has made a huge commitment to stop “directly or indirectly” importing Russian oil (which Indian officials are yet to confirm). And finally, India has expressed its intent to “purchase \$500 billion of U.S. energy products, aircraft and aircraft parts, precious metals, technology products, and coking coal over the next 5 years”. Mr. Trump has imposed this condition to ensure that henceforth, India cannot maintain the positive balance in its trade with the U.S., which it currently enjoys.

The interim agreement has found support in some quarters of the country. Advocates of the agreement point out that the reduction in U.S. tariffs would provide opportunities to Indian businesses to expand their presence in the world's biggest economy. They argue that India's labour-intensive products, especially textiles and clothing, would enjoy a competitive edge over the products of its neighbours in South and Southeast Asia since they face higher U.S. tariffs. But this



Lingering doubts: Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge with other opposition MPs protest the India-U.S. interim trade deal outside Parliament in New Delhi on February 12. ANI

purported advantage would be considerably diluted as the U.S. and Bangladesh have also announced their trade deal on February 9, under which certain textile and clothing products from Bangladesh would enjoy duty-free access into the U.S.

Protecting farmers interests

The interim agreement raises several uncomfortable questions on a wide spectrum of issues, from its likely impact on several key stakeholders in India, particularly farmers, to the ability of the Indian government to take sovereign decisions in critical areas.

One, the interim agreement does not explicitly state that India would not reduce tariff-sensitive agricultural products, especially cereals, as has been the case in all its Free Trade Agreements

(FTAs), including the recent EU-India FTA. Does this absence of a clear statement that tariff protection on cereals would be maintained, suggest that India has yielded to Mr. Trump's pressures to comprehensively open India's agricultural market to U.S. agri-business? Serious doubts arose regarding this possibility when the U.S. Secretary of Agriculture, Brooke Rollins tweeted that the U.S.-India deal would help “export more American farm products to India's massive market, lifting prices, and pumping cash into rural America”. The Government of India must ensure that the final deal with the U.S. unambiguously states that imports of cereals from the U.S. would not be allowed, which is the sole guarantee for protecting farmers' livelihoods and also the country's hard earned food security. This is also critical for the government's

credibility as Prime Minister Narendra Modi during last year's Independence Day speech had assured farmers that their interests would be protected in a trade deal with the U.S.

Unanswered questions

Two, the interim agreement states that India would address the long-standing Non-Tariff Barriers (NTBs) to trade of U.S. food and agricultural products in recognition of the importance of working together to resolve U.S.'s long-standing concerns. The U.S. has consistently opposed India's refusal to import Genetically Modified (GM) food products, long considered as India's most significant NTB on food products. By agreeing to resolve “long standing concerns” in the interim agreement, has the government allowed imports of GM food products?

Three, why has the government accepted the most unequal trade agreement by eliminating tariffs and non-tariff barriers on U.S. imports, while allowing the U.S. to impose 18% tariffs on India's exports? It may be noted that before Mr. Trump began his tariff war, average U.S. tariffs on India's exports was around 2.5%, implying that India has allowed a seven-fold increase in tariff protection on its exports to the U.S. Four, why has India accepted such an unequal deal when the legitimacy of Mr. Trump's tariffs are been questioned in U.S. courts, and, more importantly, when several countries, including Brazil and China have refused to yield to Mr. Trump's pressures? And finally, why has the government allowed the Trump Administration to maintain surveillance on India's oil imports? Mr. Trump has directed his administration to reimpose 25% additional tariffs if India resumes its Russian oil imports. This raises a much larger question; hasn't the Government of India's acquiescence opened the door for U.S. surveillance to extend to more sensitive areas that could challenge India's sovereignty?

Biswajit Dhar is former professor, Jawaharlal Nehru University.

THE GIST

Advocates of the agreement point out that the reduction in U.S. tariffs would provide opportunities to Indian businesses to expand their presence in the world's biggest economy.

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The U.S. has consistently opposed India's refusal to import Genetically Modified (GM) food products, long considered as India's most significant NTB on food products.

What are bio-based chemicals and enzymes?

How is India positioned with respect to scaling bio-based chemicals and enzymes?

Shambhavi Naik

The story so far:

Bio-based chemicals are industrial chemicals produced using biological feedstocks like sugarcane, corn, starch, or biomass residues, often through fermentation or enzymatic processes. Examples include organic acids (such as lactic acid), bio-alcohols, solvents, surfactants, and intermediates used in plastics, cosmetics, and pharmaceuticals. Enzymes are biological catalysts widely used in detergents, food processing, pharmaceuticals, textiles, pulp and paper, and increasingly in biomanufacturing. Enzymes often work at lower temperatures and pressures, reducing energy use and emissions.

Why does India need such chemicals? India has strong fundamentals for scaling bio-based chemicals and enzymes: a large

agricultural base, deep expertise in fermentation from pharmaceuticals and vaccines, and a growing manufacturing sector. Expanding this space could reduce import dependence on petrochemicals, create new markets for agricultural produce, and position India as a competitive supplier of sustainable industrial inputs. For example, India imported roughly \$479.8 million worth of acetic acid in 2023.

Where does India stand today?

India has prioritised bio-based chemicals and enzymes as a priority area under the Department of Biotechnology's BioE3 policy. In the bio-based chemicals segment, companies such as Praj Industries and Godrej Industries are leading. Other firms such as Godavari Biorefineries are pioneering ethanol-based, bio-derived chemicals in India, while Jubilant Ingrevia produces “acetyls” intermediates (for example,

acetic anhydride/ethyl acetate). Emerging companies such as StringBio are using novel microbial strategies to develop such chemicals. The India enzymes market is consolidated in nature with top players accounting for more than 75% of the market share. Companies such as Novozymes India, DuPont, DSM, Advance Enzyme Technologies, BASF SE, and Ultraze Enzymes Private Limited are key players in the Indian market.

What are other countries doing?

The EU Bioeconomy Strategy and Action Plan provides coordinated support for bio-based chemicals as part of circular bioeconomy goals. It links industrial transformation to climate goals, waste reduction, and sustainable growth. In the U.S., the USDA BioPreferred Program mandates federal procurement preference for certified bio-based products, including chemicals and enzymes, creating early markets for

producers. China's bioeconomy development plans explicitly prioritise high-value bio-based chemicals and enzyme technologies as strategic sectors. In Japan, priority projects funded through METI/NARO integrate bio-based chemical research with manufacturing readiness.

What are the risks?

A key risk in developing the bio-based chemicals sector is the comparative cost of bio-based products relative to petrochemical alternatives. While this cost disadvantage may be temporary and limited to early stages of scale-up, it nonetheless creates a significant entry barrier for private investment. A second risk relates to the availability of reliable feedstocks and supporting infrastructure required to produce different categories of bio-based chemicals at scale. A third challenge lies in market adoption – specifically, whether bio-based chemicals can seamlessly substitute existing inputs in manufacturing pipelines and whether downstream manufacturers are willing to switch, even when costs are comparable.

Scaling shared biomanufacturing infrastructure – such as biofoundries, pilot plants, and demonstration facilities under BioE3 – can reduce capital risk for firms. Clear standards, certification, and procurement policies can help create build investor confidence.

The author is chairperson, Takshashila Institution's Health & Life Sciences Policy.

THE GIST

India has prioritised bio-based chemicals and enzymes as a priority area under the Department of Biotechnology's BioE3 policy.

The India enzymes market is consolidated in nature with top players accounting for more than 75% of the market share.

A key risk in developing the bio-based chemicals sector is the comparative cost of bio-based products relative to petrochemical alternatives.

Kaarwaan from 'Of Worlds Within Worlds' by Gulammohammed Sheikh at KNMA Delhi in 2025. FILE PHOTO

With works spanning decades on display at Kochi, and a new volume on 13 artist-friends out just last month, Gulammohammed Sheikh, artist, poet, art historian, and pedagogue, remains ever-curious, moving between art, history, and poetry

Sheikh often speaks of having experienced three births in his life. The first, of course, was his biological birth in 1937, into a lower middle-class Sunni Muslim family in Surendranagar, a small town in the Saurashtra region of Gujarat, where he spent the first 18 years of his life. The second came in 1955, when, on

The first comprehensive study of Sheikh's art and life was by Chaitanya Sambrani in *At Home in the World*. The book brings together all his major works up to its publication in 2019, situating them alongside biographical details woven into the broader chronological narrative of independent India. Essays by critics such as Coilin Parsons offer insights into Sheikh's artistic practice and his enduring contribution to contemporary Indian art.

Gulammmohammed Sheikh: Kaarawaan is an exhibition catalogue published in conjunction with Sheikh's solo exhibition, 'Kaarawaan and Other Works', presented by Vadehra Art Gallery at Bikaner House, New Delhi, in the winter of 2024. The exhibition marked Sheikh's first solo show after a gap of 13 years. One of its largest works, also titled 'Kaarawaan', appears to gather everything the artist has experienced, lived, and loved into a giant boat, recalling the great Indian painter Nainsukh in *A Boat Adrift on a River*. The painting is an amalgamation of artworks, artists, and ideas from across the world that have influenced Sheikh over six decades. A close reading of its details reveals figures such as Gauri Lankesh and M.M. Kalburgi alongside Rabindranath Tagore, Pablo Picasso, and others. Sheikh's vessel drifts through the tumultuous waters of our time, bearing witness to history and the present. Mahatma Gandhi and Kabir are two

Mehul Devkala is a poet, writer and award-winning filmmaker



It is maddening to listen to him go on and on about his loss at the championship

I think we all need a break. We need to get away from the madding crowd.

This is a word which is limited to informal contexts – according to standard dictionaries, it is used for the purpose of humour. ‘Splendiferous’ comes from ‘splendour’, and when you describe something as being splendidferous, what you are suggesting is that it is truly wonderful or excellent. It is a shade better than ‘splendour’.

Visual: A radio adaptation of a book by H. G. Wells triggered panic because it said this was going to happen. **Ans: Alien invasion from Mars**

Early Birds: Tamal Biswas| Parimal Das| Mohan Lal Patel| Sadhan Panda| Sudhir Thapa